Primed by Cortex

MAGE

The Ascension



A guide to Cortex Prime system conversion

Credits

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Mage: The Ascension Conversion

This is a tabletop roleplaying game inspired by rules originally published as Cortex Lite, that was designed as a "generic" tabletop RPG to be used in any setting.

Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex is compatible with *Cortex Prime* roleplaying game system.

Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex is an adaptation of Mage: The Ascension, a classic World of Darkness game about mages living in the shadows of a world akin to ours.

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What is Mage?

Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex is a tabletop roleplaying game of urban fantasy, gothic punk, ambition, freedom, power and shifting realities built on rules inspired by *Cortex Prime*. The simple yet extremely powerful and encompassing rules will allow you to experience a familiar world of *Mage* with new and exciting rules that are closer to modern narrative games.

In a tabletop roleplaying game such as this one, players each take a role of a character or multiple. **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** characters exist in a world much like ours, but darker, painted in gothic tones and punk sounds. The shadows are darker, the urban decay stronger, and the inequalities highlighted. Mages, vampires, demons, werewolves and countless occult creatures inhabit the shadows. They walk among mortals and pretend to be them, all while navigating their own complex worlds of intrigue, politics, secret wars and mysteries.

Who Are You?

You are a mage, a person who can reshape reality through sheer force of will. In a moment of clarity you Awakened to your potential and the mutable nature of reality, and such you are able to change the very world with your belief and action.

And you are not the only one. The world is filled with mages like you. They walk among mortals and monsters, waging the age-old secret war over reality. Mystic mages of Crafts and Traditions combat the march of technology stewarded by the Technocracy and their vision of global progress, as reality is defined by the collective belief of humanity.

But, as you can see by the very device you're reading this on, Technocracy has been winning, and in their success calcified reality and human belief more and more, forcing every mage into the shadows, lest they be rendered apart by the opposing force of human disbelief for performing the wonders of magick and hypertechnology in clear view.

You are one of those extraordinary people, who will *you* be in this world of mystery and strife?

How to play Mage

This section is inspired by and remixes some of the player-facing rules from Cortex Lite and MoonLite.

PCs & ST

As in many tabletop role-playing games, one player takes on the role of the game moderator, called Storyteller, or ST in Mage, rather than playing their own character. The ST frames scenes, portrays supporting characters (called STCs, or Storyteller Characters), controls the opposition (including rolling dice), ends scenes, and maintains a special ongoing pool of dice called the peril pool.

The characters portrayed by everybody else are called player characters, or PCs.

Rolling Dice

During play, everybody contributes to the story, but at some point you break out dice, introducing just enough randomness so no one knows what will happen until events unfold during play.

When you want your character to do something, if there's nothing getting in your way, you just do it. If there is opposition (such as an opponent, difficult circumstances, a harsh environment, or a time limit), you roll the dice to figure out if you succeed or fail.

Traits & Dice

Your character is a protagonist in the story you tell in the game, as well as your primary means of interacting with both the world and the rules. Their traits and die ratings help you figure out who your character is and what they can do.

Each trait is rated between d4 and d12, each represented in this text with a symbol: d4 – a 4-sided die, d6 – a 6-sided die, d8 – an 8-sided die, d10 – a 10-sided die, or d12 – a 12-sided die.

A d4 trait is underdeveloped or problematic, a d6 is healthy and reliable, a d8 is excellent and noteworthy, a d10 is extraordinary and powerful, and a d12 is world-class, the absolute pinnacle of your potential and capabilities.

Traits are organized into trait sets, that are: distinctions, attributes, roles, specialities, signature assets, and Spheres that will be expanded on later.

Your Dice Pool

Whenever you roll, you must take a distinction, an attribute, and a role, one each from corresponding sets in one pool of dice.

In cases where another one of your traits may help you may also add one speciality, as many assets as are appropriate, a Sphere if you are performing magick to your dice pool.

Your Total

After rolling all your dice, you add two of the die results of your choice that aren't 1 together for your total. The total is often, but not always, the two highest results.

Your total affects whether you succeed or fail at an action, so the higher the total the better.

Your Effect Die

After choosing die results for your total, you pick one of the other dice you rolled to be your effect die. The number rolled doesn't matter, as long as it isn't one, what matters is the die rating itself.

Effect die doesn't affect whether you succeed or fail, instead determining how successful your action was, so the higher your effect die the more successful you were.

Opposition

When you roll, another player (often the Storyteller, ST) builds their own dice pool and rolls it, taking their own total and effect die. You compare your roll's total to theirs, and the higher roll succeeds.

The player who rolls first sets the bar for how difficult the roll should be, so the initiating player wins ties.

Success

If you win, the size of your effect die (not the number it rolled) determines how big of an effect your success had. You might say, "My effect die is 8."

For example, if you roll to hit someone with a weapon, your total determines whether you hit (like comparing an attack roll to armour class in the world's most popular RPG), and your effect die would be how much damage you inflict.

Your total tells you whether the story goes your way; your effect die tells you how far it goes.

An Example of Play

Lydia, a fashionista Hermetic mage of small height and large personality, is going home late in the evening after shopping for fabric, but a suspicious man is following her. The player describes Lydia grabbing a burning spider amulet on her neck, recalling Pattern classifications, and whispering a perceptive spell to read the man's aura.

The ST asks them for a dice roll to see if the succeeds. The decide to roll her traits Scout 6, Alertness 8, House Verditius Wondercrafter 8, and Prime 6, getting 4 and 7 on 8s, 3 and 2 on 6s.

They pick 4 and 7 to add together for a total of 11, and use one of the remaining 6s as the effect die.

The man's total against her is 10, and since 11 is higher, Lydia wins. She gets to keep that 8 effect as her read in the man. Her eyes fall upon the man, the spell pierces a strange film concealing him, and Lydia sees the bright, yet pale reddish-pink aura of a vampire on the hunt, she's in trouble.

Lydia's roll				Opposition's roll		
2	3	4	7	3	6	4

Table 1: Example roll, dice added to total are green, effect die is purple

The Shape of Mage

If that explanation all made sense, then you know how to play **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex**. Everything else in the system fits into, bolts onto, or adds a twist to this single mechanic. The rest of this section breaks down more advanced rules that build on those fundamentals.

Session Zero and Safety Tools

Playing a tabletop RPG can become a bad experience if everyone involved isn't on the same page about the topics and themes they'll be exploring in play. The best way to align those expectations is usually having a formal process, making sure everyone has a chance to be heard and set appropriate boundaries. That process can be a part of a "Session Zero", a conversation before actual play begins that can also provide a chance to make characters together, discuss the game, build anticipation, and decide what kind of content should or shouldn't be a part of the game.

You should also use appropriate safety tools, such as **Lines and Veils**, the **X-Card by John Stavropoulos** or Script Change by **Beau Jágr Sheldon**. Script Change is especially recommended, because the framework it provides can improve the experience of playing a tabletop RPG even when content concerns aren't an issue. What's important is choosing the tools that work for you and your group.

Sessions, Scenes, & Beats

Games are played in sessions. A session is just however long you and your group gather to play at a time, whether in-person or online.

Each session is divided into units of story and action called scenes, just like a play, film, or TV show.

Player actions take place in units of time called beats. A beat is simply how long it takes to complete one action or one piece of a larger action (including both the die roll to do something and the roll opposing it).

Action Order

Normally, a player can just roll a test or describe their character's actions whenever it makes sense, as part of the game's ongoing conversation. When it's helpful to organize things a bit more, the ST can move things into action order.

- When the game is in action order, the scene splits into *rounds*. A round is nothing more or less than the amount of time it takes for every participant in a scene to take one beat's worth of action (often called a *turn*).
- Usually, the ST chooses one player to go first. After a player takes a beat, they choose who goes next. The ST and any STCs active in the scene get to take their own beats as well. Once everyone has taken a beat to do what they want to do, the round ends.
- Whoever goes last in a round chooses who goes first in the next round, which can be themself!

Plot Points

This game uses a special currency called plot points (abbreviated PP), which you can spend to affect the story. You'll likely earn and spend plot points all the time. Every player gets at least one PP at the start of each session.

The most important uses of plot points include:

- You can spend a PP to instantly create a 6 asset.
- When you add up die results for your total, you can spend a PP to add in the result from one additional die, increasing your total.
- When choosing an effect die, you can spend a PP to keep an additional effect die as a different effect on the same target or to inflict the same effect on multiple targets.
- You can spend a PP to make an asset useful to a whole group of people instead of just one.
- When an asset would go away at the end of a scene or session, you can spend a PP to keep it, starting the next scene or session with the asset still in play.

The main ways of earning plot points are:

- Rolling a distinction at 4 as per *Hinder*.
- Getting a 1 on a die and getting a PP from the Storyteller.
- Activating a Limit.
- Performing obvious magick in front of mortal witnesses.

All of these ways of earning PPs will be explained further later on in the book.

Unless specified otherwise, you can spend plot points at any time, even when it isn't your beat or turn.

Any unspent plot points are lost at the end of a session, so it's best not to hoard them.

The ST doesn't have plot points, but they can influence the story in a similar way by using the dice in their peril pool.

Hitches & Botches

When you roll 1 on a die, you can't count that die towards your total or use it for your effect die.

A die that rolls a 1 is called a hitch. When you roll a hitch, the ST can decide grant you a PP to add a die to their peril pool. The more hitches you roll, the larger the die added. You can't refuse the PP offered.

If every die in a pool hitches it's called a botch, and it means ST can use all the hitches without paying you a plot point.

When the ST rolls a hitch, it's called an opportunity. When the ST rolls an opportunity, you can spend a PP to step up an existing asset or step down a complication.

Heroic Success

When you succeed on a roll, if your total beats the opposing roll by 5 or more, you've scored a heroic success. This means that you not only achieve what you set out to do, but surpass your own expectations in doing so. For every 5 by which you beat the opposing roll, your effect die steps up by one size.

Effect Dice

When you succeed on a roll, your effect die usually becomes an asset (a new temporary trait that benefits someone) or a complication (a new temporary trait that makes things harder for someone).

When an asset or complication is created, it gains a name to go with its die rating, such as **Bound** 10, **Careful Plan** 12, **Chain Lightning Spell** 6, **Hidden** 6, **Invigorated** 10, or **Running Low on Money** 8. The player who creates an asset or complication gets to name and describe it.

Assets and complications aren't added to every roll; like other traits, they only apply when it makes sense in the story for the particular action described. The default assumption is that assets and complications go away when a scene ends.

Most rolls create some kind of complication or asset, but there are a couple other things you can do.

You might simply roll to change your situation, such as by opening a locked door. In this case, your effect die just measures your degree of success: a 4 might be getting the door open just a crack, while a 12 busts it wide open.

You might also roll to step down or end a complication; this is called recovery, and the rules for it are explained later.

Comparing Effect Dice

Even when you fail a roll against someone, your effect die still matters. If your roll fails, but your effect die is larger than the opposition's effect die, the opposition's effect die steps down.

Extra Effects

When you want to achieve multiple outcomes from a single roll (including affecting more than one target), you can do so by spending plot points to keep extra effect dice beyond the first.

For each PP spent, you can choose one extra die from your roll to become an effect die. You can't choose hitches or dice that are already effect dice or part of your total. If you run out of dice to choose from, you can't keep more effect dice.

Each effect die must do enact a different effect. For example if you are fighting a duo of Technocratic automata in an Umbral realm, you can use two effect dice to assign a **Stepping Sideways** complication to each automaton, or to assign both **Stepping Sideways** and a **Short-circuiting** complication to the same automaton, but you can't use extra effect dice to assign **Stepping Sideways** to the same automaton more than once with the same roll.

Also, if you assign effect dice to multiple targets that each have their own dice to roll, each target gets their own opposition roll against you. Only those you beat take the effect.

When you step up a 12 effect die, you gain an extra 6 effect die for that roll.

There's Always an Effect

Every roll always has a minimum of one 4 effect die. If stepping down dice, removing dice due to hitches, or any other situation would prevent a roll from having an effect die, give that roll one 4 effect die before resolving it.

Complications

A complication is a temporary trait that makes things harder for you, so you don't roll it yourself. Instead, your opposition can roll it against you, and if someone else has a complication, you can add it to your dice pool when rolling against them.

Here's a sample list of complications that you might inflict (or suffer) during play: **Poisoned**, **Electrocuted**, **On Fire**, **Out of Money**, **Hexed to Misfortune**, **Bound and Gagged**.

No 4 Complications

Unlike other traits that run from 4 to 12, 4 complications do not exist in **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex**. When you take a new complication, if it would be 4 or smaller, it becomes a 6. When an existing complication would step down to less than 6, it just goes away.

Taken Out

If a complication on any character would step up to a die size larger than 12, the complication stays at 12, but that character is taken out.

When you are taken out, you are unable to influence the story – one way or another, you've been overwhelmed and can no longer take actions. When someone gets banished into the Umbra, is blown away by a tornado, knocked out by a brigand, or is petrified by magic, they've been taken out. Being taken out usually only lasts until the end of the scene.

Stepping Up Complications

An important rule of complications is that an existing one can be stepped up by further actions that inflict the same complication. So, if you already have a **On Fire** 6 complication, and someone adds fuel to the blaze or fires a phosphorous round at you, that complication could step up to 8. Each time another roll worsens your complication, its effect die steps it up. If the effect die is larger than the complication's rating, the complication steps up to that effect die's size.

When naming a complication, it is best to use a name that leaves room for things to get worse – it might get stepped up, after all. Instead of naming a complication **Paralysed**, it makes more sense to call it or **Going Stiff** or **Muscle Spasms**. So if a spell that would turn a character to stone inflicts a complication rather than taking the character out, the complication might just be called **Turning to Stone**, as the character's body slowly petrifies, their muscles stiffen, skin goes hard and brittle and their limbs become heavy and slow.

Complications can also be renamed when circumstances change. If a character already trapped in a net is then pushed into quicksand, their complication might go from **Tangled Up** 8 to **Restrained** 10, changing the name to include all the problems limiting their ability to move and escape.

Stress

The most common forms of complications are called stress. These are the kinds of consequences that befall characters all the time. While they work just like complications in all other respects, they have their own rules for when they go away.

Stress vs. Complications

When something happens that makes things harder for a character, but it isn't covered by one of the stress types, represent it with a free-form complication instead, such as **Tangled**, **Grappled**, **Bound by Spell**, **Electroshocked**, **Blinded**, **Fading Into Umbra**, **Turning Into A Lawn Chair**, etc.

Failure & Stress

When you fail a test, you take 6 stress. The opposition chooses the type of stress. Perhaps a character feels **Demoralised** by their lack of success, **Drained** by the wasted effort, or **Enthralled** by an interesting problem they can't seem to solve yet.

Types of Stress

Five kinds of stress are used in **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex**: **Damaged** stress, **Demoralised** stress, **Drained** stress, **Enraged** stress, and **Enthralled** stress. Each type of stress represents a different kind of situation, as follows:

Damaged stress is physical, bodily harm, like getting punched in the eye, cut by a blade, poisoned by an assassin, burned by flame, etc.

Demoralised stress is fear, insecurity, discouragement, worry, disillusionment, or any other mental state that makes you feel like you might be better off quitting.

Drained stress is lack of energy, fatigue or burnout for Sleepers, but for mages it is also depletion of their Avatar of Quintessence, the force of creation they can use to bolster their reality-altering magick.

Supernatural creatures like mages can never recover **Drained** stress except via SFX.

Enthralled stress is when you are fascinated, tempted, distracted, charmed, smitten, mind-controlled, or just caught up in your own thoughts.

Enraged stress is anger, wrath, and aggression.

Assets

An asset is a temporary trait that grants an advantage. When you create an asset, you choose whether it is for you or for another character. Unless stated otherwise, only the character you choose can use it.

Sometimes, an asset becomes permanent, making it an ongoing advantage that a character uses all the time. Such assets are called signature assets.

A default rule for assets is that, unlike other types of traits, more than one asset can be added to the same dice pool, as long as each asset is being applied to the activity for which the player is rolling.

Assets are possibly the most basic trait in the game, but there are a lot of ways this versatile trait can feature in your fantasy game.

You can create an asset with a test. Your effect die becomes the rating of the asset, which you may use for the rest of the scene. Here's some assets that you might create during play: **Conjured Thunder**, **Covered by Terrain**, **Suggestive Appearance**, **Expansive Reconnaissance**.

Shutting Down Assets

Whether it is disarming the garou's knaive, quashing the bloodlust of an angry mob, or unweaving a ward of your opponent, you may want to remove the assets of characters giving you trouble. To do so, you roll against that character, and they get to include the asset in their dice pool opposing you.

On a success, you either:

- shut down the asset if your effect die is larger than the asset
- or step down the asset if your effect die is equal or lower

When you step down an asset in this way or make it unavailable, it remains so until the end of the scene. Any player may do this by inflicting a complication larger than the asset's rating. You can do it all in one go, or by starting a low-level complication like **Loosened Grip** and stepping it up with later rolls. When you step down an asset in this way or make it unavailable, it remains stepped down or shut down until the end of the scene. If the asset would've gone away at the end of the scene, that happens normally.

Recovery

Complications and stress can be downright crippling. Getting rid of complications or stress is called recovery.

Free-form complications go away at the end of a scene or when they are no longer narratively appropriate. While stress is "stickier" and recovering is takes downtime: a scene when characters have a chance to recover – by resting or some other form of self-care and recovery – all stress dice except **Drained** step down.

Drained can only be recovered by downtime or other means when you have access to free Quintessence or special magickal practices.

Seizing an Opportunity

When the ST rolls an opportunity, you can spend a PP to step down a complication or stress.

Recovery Rolls

Other characters can try to help you recover. (Generally, you can't recover your own stress unless you have an SFX that allows it.)

To do so, the helping character rolls a test against a difficulty of 8 8 or peril, per ST's choice, plus the complication or stress die that they are trying to help you with.

On a success, they either step down your complication or stress, if their effect die is equal or smaller to its die, or remove the complication or stress entirely, if their effect die is larger.

On most failures, nothing happens. If they fail with one or more hitches, your complication or stress steps up and the ST gives both of you a PP.

Fresh Start

At the start of a new session, all complications and stresses are removed – unless the last session ended in a cliffhanger and the new session picks up right where you left off. (If that's the case, players keep their PP as well.)

SFX & Dice Tricks

Your character gains SFX, special effects that give you added influence over the story. These reflect your character's extraordinary abilities or their powerful role in the narrative. Many SFX require you to spend plot points to activate them. Other SFX allow you to impose a disadvantage on your character in order to earn PP or another reward. For example, the *Hinder* SFX lets you earn a PP by rolling a smaller die.

Using an SFX is always a choice; you are never compelled to activate your character's SFX, unless that SFX is a Limit. A Limit is an SFX which can be activated by the ST.

Doubling Dice

Sometimes, the rules tell you to double a die in your pool. When you double a die, you add another die of the same size to the pool before you roll.

One Roll

Unless the text of the SFX itself or another rule says otherwise, when you step up, step down, or double a trait using an SFX, you only do so for a single roll.

Reroll

Some SFX allow a reroll of some or all of the dice in your pool after you first roll them. You can't use SFX to reroll the same die roll more than once, though other players might use SFX to reroll it.

Usually, SFX of this type specify how many dice are rerolled. If an SFX says to reroll all the dice, or if it doesn't specify, reroll every die rolled as part of that dice pool.

Stepping Up & Stepping Down

The rules sometimes tell you to step up a die, changing it from a die of one size to one of the next larger size, (such as changing 4 to 6 or 8 to 10) or to step down a die (the reverse, such as 12 to 10).

When you step up a 12 in your dice pool, you keep the 12, but add an extra 6 to your pool as well. When you step down a 4 in your pool, you remove that die entirely.

Stepping Down Assets

When an SFX allows you step down an asset for some benefit, that asset remains so indefinitely unless the SFX says otherwise. It can still be stepped up by normal means (such as activating an opportunity). If an asset is stepped down below 4, it is eliminated. Signature assets are restored to their full value at the end of the scene.

Stepping Down Stress or Complications

When an SFX lets you step down a stress or complication, it remains stepped down indefinitely, as if with a successful recovery roll, unless the SFX says otherwise. (So if an SFX lets you step down someone's **Damaged**, for example, you have applied healing to their injury.)

Using Your Own Complications

Some SFX let you add your own complication or stress to your dice pool for a roll. When you do so, the opposition doesn't get to roll that complication or stress against you – you're already using it to your own advantage, so in that moment it isn't a disadvantage for you.

SFX & Magick

Some of the SFX allow you to perform magickal effects without rolling your Spheres, but to be able to unlock the SFX and use the effect created by it, you must have the narrative permissions by having the Sphere rating that would allow you to produce the effect normally.

Also, all magick-related SFX are subject to all the rules Paradox, such as Paradox growth by vulgar magick, that are described further.

The Peril Pool

During play, the ST maintains their own special, ongoing pool of dice that represents the overall ebb and flow of trouble and danger across the entire adventure. This is the peril pool, and when a player rolls a test, the ST usually rolls the peril pool to oppose them. Dice in the peril pool are called peril dice.

At the opening of a new adventure, the ST establishes the peril pool as a matched pair of two dice. It usually starts each session at 6 6, but it can be 8 8 or higher depending on the stakes of the story.

Whenever a player roll a hitch, if the ST wants to take advantage of it, the ST gives that player a PP, then adds 6 to the peril pool. If the player rolled multiple hitches, the ST can step up the new 6 peril die once for each additional hitch beyond the first (8 for two hitches, 10 for three hitches, or 12 for four).

Also, whenever the rules say the ST would gain a PP (such as by activating a Limit for a STC), they gain a 6 peril die instead.

Whenever the ST would add a new die to the peril pool, they can instead choose to step up an existing peril die.

When the ST adds a peril die, they may also describe something that has happened in the scene to make life more complicated for one or more player characters.

The ST can also "spend" peril dice from the peril pool, removing them from the peril pool to activate certain special rules during play (as described in the ST section). For example, the ST can spend peril dice as if they were plot points for STCs, which is the main way peril dice are spent.

Paradox

During play, every character also maintains their own special challenge pool that represents the force of consensual reality fighting back against the enlightened will of the mage. This is their Paradox pool.

When Paradox grows ST either steps up one of Paradox dice or adds a 6 to Paradox – two if the pool was empty. A character grows their Paradox in multiple ways:

- Whenever they use vulgar magick, Paradox grows once and the player gains a PP.
- Whenever they use vulgar magick in front of Sleeper witnesses, Paradox grows twice and the player gains 2 PPs.
- Whenever they roll a hitch using magick, the Storyteller may grow Paradox as per peril rules, paying for it as normal.
- Special circumstances: Certain special circumstances like encounters with Mad Ones may grow Paradox in unusual ways as well.

Paradox gets to roll against the character (as described in the ST section for Challenges) if their Paradox grew. If Paradox succeeds, they get to inflict a complication, representing the form Backlash takes, be it Quiet, Burn, a Paradox flaw or spirit.

If a PC accumulates enough Paradox, then the ST may spend from the peril pool to put them in a Paradox realm.

The PC can reduce Paradox like any challenge, taking an action on their turn to steel themselves before the might of reality hitting them. Success results in a Paradox flaw that has a relatively harmless effect.

Conditions

Characters may find themselves experiencing all kinds of conditions: getting turned into a lawn chair, using magick to turn invisible, having a pursuer shoot out one of your tires, gaining increased confidence from an inspiring speech, and the like. In **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex**, these kinds of conditions are modelled with assets, complications, and stress.

Spellcasting Conditions

As a default, hitches on rolls to use magick almost always inflict Paradox on the caster.

Sometimes mages use Quintessence to make their magicks blaze with reality, brilliance, and power when imposing their Will over the world. **Drained** stress describes their Avatar's reserves dwindling.

Hitches might occasionally result in other conditions, as the ST determines. Channelling hitched lightning might shock you as well, for instance, and inflict **Damaged**, and a hitched prophecy might fill one with dread, inflicting **Demoralised** instead.

Botches can grow Paradox immensely, but they can also be opportunities for mistargeted, uncontrolled magickal effects going terribly awry.

Other complications can interfere with performing magick, depending on the mage's instruments. A mage relying on voice and vocalisations who is **Silenced** on **Gagged**, one who uses movement and gestures but has their fingers **Bound**, or one who writes the code to reality but had **Electronics Taken Away** has those complications rolled against their in tests to perform magickal effects. Equivalent complications might afflict mages with different practices. A player might also *Hinder* a distinction to recognize the limitations of their training – and pick up a sweet PP for their trouble.

Tactical Conditions

A simple test can inflict complications such as **Surrounded**, **Outflanked**, or **Exposed**, or create assets like **Covering Fire**, **In Position**, or **Got the Drop On You**. If an asset applies to multiple characters, spend a PP to let everybody in the group use it.

A feint can inflict a complication to the tune of **Distracted** or **Unbalanced**, which can then be leveraged in a later roll to inflict more lasting **Damaged**.

Disarming an opponent can also work as a complication. If the item is represented by an asset die, inflicting a complication of a higher die size makes the asset inaccessible until the complication is recovered.

Morale Conditions

Intimidation both on and off the battlefield is neatly handled by inflicting **Demoralised** stress. That stress, in turn, can be rolled into other actions seeking to inflict **Damaged** or other conditions. It can even be added to dice pools to scare opponents into quitting the battlefield altogether.

The trade-off is that, in most situations, **Demoralised** stress is likely easier to recover than "more serious" conditions like **Damaged**, which might require skilled help, specialized tools, or magick. Any character can offer encouragement to any other character as an action intended to recover **Demoralised** stress. Characters can even attempt to psych themselves up and recover their own stress.

Magical Conditions

A whole raft of magical conditions can simply be flashy ways of inflicting basic stress. A fascination charm inflicts **Enthralled**. A Prime effect draining your pattern of energy inflicts **Drained**. And of course fireballs inflict **Damaged**.

Sometimes you might want something a little more tailored to your circumstances, in which complications come into play. **On Fire** is a perennial favourite. **Blinded**, **Poisoned**, **Bound into Concrete**, or even **Chilled** work great, as well. Cursing a man to have a donkey's head, if we want to get all Shakespearean, can also just be expressed as a complication.

Mages may also spend a PP to keep an extra effect die. This way you can inflict a standard stress like **Damaged** as well as a flashy complication like **On Fire**.

Some magical conditions, such as turning someone into a lawn chair, can get tricky. Here the intent is not to complicate their later actions, but to remove the character from the scene entirely. Such a complication may need to be rephrased as an active but unfinished process, like **Becoming a Lawn Chair**.

Stealth Conditions

Characters sneaking past guards or into rooms without being noticed is usually resolved with a simple test. However if the player intends to leverage that "stealthed" status in later actions, they might spend a PP to gain the asset **Stealthed** or **In the Shadows**

Alternately, a character might take action to distract sentries or other opponents. Their intent may be to strike while distracted or shepherd less-stealthy characters past. Such a distraction can also be handled with a test, this time inflicting **Enthralled** stress, to represent the target's attention being focused elsewhere, or a temporary complication representing a specific distraction, such as **Burning Police Car** 3. Both the surprise attack and other characters' stealth attempts may then add the complication into their die pool.

Both assets and complications are eliminated whenever they are no longer relevant. When a **Stealthed** character reveals themself, the asset goes away. When the sentries are no longer distracted, the complication goes away.

The classic Rogue tactic of striking from the shadows can combine both a **Stealthed** asset and a distracting complication, which is one of the reasons this tactic is so popular and effective.

Wealth Conditions

The love of money is the root of all evil, but we live in a society where people must spend to survive. ST can freely offer characters an asset to represent wealth gained an adventure: **Fat Wallet** 6, **Stolen Credit Card** 8, **Briefcase Full of Cash** 10. Alternately, players may search a location and create an asset to represent something valuable they find.

Shopping is as simple as creating an asset with a test. Wealth assets can be added to these rolls, and on a success might be renamed (**Slimmed Down Wallet**), stepped down, or eliminated, depending on circumstance.

Like any other temporary asset, wealth assets only last for one session. A windfall is likely to be used immediately for something relevant to the plot.

If a wealth is stored away or saved up, it doesn't disappear, but either it's no longer relevant to the immediate story and therefore is no longer worth a die, or the character should spend the 5 XP required to gain it as a signature asset, representing more permanent wealth or a useful purchase they intend to carry with them on their adventures.

How to Be a Great Player

As a **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** player, part of your job is to respond to the challenges the ST lays down as well as interact with fellow player characters. The game works best when you go hard: describe your actions with cinematic energy. Instead of "I strike the zombie with lightning", you can draw your oaken want inscribed with sacred name of Baraquiel, the angel of lightning and speak the Latin incantation of Creo Fulmen to put the dead back to rest, slap the gun out of the vampire's hand, or any number of other options. There's no increased risk to your character when you get creative, so let your imagination run wild.

One enthusiastically descriptive player is entertaining, but the good stuff is when the whole table starts riffing off each other's antics. Keep an eye out for opportunities to interact and open yourself up to others piling on to your fun. Be vocal: say "I need to shake this **Demoralised** stress!" or "I'm gonna pin them in place with a complication, so you can finish them off!" The game works better – both tactically and narratively – if everybody is a part of everybody else's stories.

There's literally no limit on what any of you can describe except the nature of the story itself, which means the tone and mood of the game is entirely in your hands. This is a collaborative effort; it's not the sole responsibility of any one player to decide what is or is not too silly, or too dark, or too outlandish. Talk about the kind of action, drama, and comedy you want to see in the game. If things start drifting in a direction that's not fun for you, speak up so you can all stay on the same page.

Characters & Traits

In this chapter you will learn what your mage is made of, what traits constitute him, and how he can influence the story with his dice.

Faction & Focus

When creating a character, choose one Faction, which grants you SFX and Limits to unlock when growing your character. Choosing a Faction should be your first decision because it defines many things about your character. The playable factions detailed in this document are: the Council of Ten Mystic Traditions and the Technocratic Union. Details on each appear in the Factions section. If you aren't affiliated with any Faction you are known as an Orphan, an unaffiliated mage.

Once you choose a Faction, you should also define your focus, which describes the way you understand the reality and how you enforce your Awakened Will upon the world. Focus has three parts making it up:

- A model for understanding how the world works. That's your paradigm.
- A system or multiple systems that allow to apply the paradigm in the real world. That's your practice.
- A number of tools, techniques and processes that prepare an act of magick in accordance with your practice, normally seven of them. Those are your instruments.

Later in the book examples of foci will be given, but those are not exhaustive, so you should feel free to define your focus yourself.

Distinctions

Much of your character is defined by three distinctions, words or brief phrases describing core aspects of their identity. Each distinction is rated ◆8. While attributes and roles describe what your character is good at, distinctions summarize who your character is.

Another difference between distinctions and some trait sets is that you name your distinctions, instead of assigning ratings to predefined traits.

- **Background** is your first distinction, it includes some description of the character's identity in the mortal world along with a personality trait or some other idiosyncrasy. Most mages started life as normal humans, so this distinction often defines who the PC was before they joined the society of mages, but some may have a magickal upbringing, though that's rare. Examples might include **Dazzling Seamstress**, **Brilliant Overthinker Graduate**, **Pessimistic Radio Technician**, **Transformed Tree**, or **Burnt Our Child Star**.
- **Faction** distinction includes the faction of mages you belong to, as well as your role in it. Some examples are **Chronicler of a Celestial Chorus Chantry**, **House Bonisagus Youngest Member**, **A Promising NWO Operative**, or **House Verditius Wondercrafter**.

- **Drive** distinction sums up a belief, focus, motivation, calling, paradigm, or mission that is central to your character. Some examples include **Must Protect My Family in Secret**, **Achieve Perfection in All I Am**, **Keep the Wheel of Dharma Spinning**, or **Find Out About my Sister's Disappearance**.

Together, your three distinctions should sum up your overall character concept. If your character were the protagonist of a book, movie, or video game, and you were describing them to a friend, your distinctions would feature prominently. Distinctions spell out how your character is different from others, and they impact every action you take.

Hindering Distinctions

Every distinction benefits from the Hinder SFX, your character's first SFX. Hinder

Hinder: Roll this distinction as a ▼ to earn a PP.

Hinder is best used in situations where a distinction would actually make things harder for the character instead of easier (such as an **Awkward Teen** trying to intimidate someone), or when no distinction really applies to what you're trying to do ("I'm a **Doctor**, not an engineer!").

Since Hinder earns you a PP, which can be spent to include extra dice in your total, this allows you to accept a temporary disadvantage now in order to succeed more spectacularly later on.

Changing Distinctions

Distinctions aren't necessarily permanent features of your character forever. Characters often evolve during play. These changes can be expressed through distinctions as well. See Spending XP later for rules to rewrite your distinctions.

Attributes

Another of your character's three major trait sets is your attributes, they represent the inherent characteristics your character possesses, there are six and for any situation there is at least one attribute that applies:

- **Agility** includes manual dexterity, swiftness, deftness, reflexes, balance, and hand-eye coordination.
- **Alertness** includes perception, intuition, attention, sensory acuity, and overall awareness of your environment.
- **Brains** includes intellect, reasoning, memory, scholarship, and aptitude for learning.
- **Brawn** includes physical strength, constitution, raw muscle, stamina, endurance, athleticism, and general health.
- **Charisma** includes presence, bearing, persuasiveness, social graces, force of personality, and personal magnetism.
- **Composure** includes willpower, self- control, tenacity, discipline, determination, resolve, and the ability to keep your emotions hidden or in-check.

Roles

Your character has five roles. While attributes represent your inherent qualities, each role trait represents a thematic grouping of experience, training, and skill.

Your largest rated role usually corresponds to how you best contribute to a group, whereas for smaller rated roles, you're often better off relying on more proficient allies. Among the roles one can be used in any situation:

- **Scholar** represents academic knowledge, including education, lore, the sciences, deduction, and research.
- **Scoundrel** sums up your knack for trickery, crime, spying, sleight of hand, defeating security measures like traps or alarms.
- **Scout** covers activities related to exploration, perception, and survival, such as tracking, navigation, animal handling, climbing, and simply noticing things.
- **Soldier** defines skill and experience when it comes to wielding weapons, enduring hardship, providing security, and fighting in general.
- **Speaker** includes communication, group dynamics, leadership, empathy, and various forms of self- expression, such as oratory, performance, and art.

Sometimes multiple roles might apply. Sneak up on a poacher with **Scout** or **Scoundrel**? Give battlefield orders with **Soldier** or **Speaker**? In those cases, choose the one your character prefers.

Specialities

Specialities are narrow skills that supplement the broad areas of expertise defined by your roles. Whenever a specialty applies, you roll it in addition to the appropriate role.

For example, you might use **Soldier** to display your general prowess with a weapon, but you might also have a specialty that you add when using certain types of weapons, such as **Firearms** 6 or **Weaponry** ◆. When you follow a trail through a dense forest, your dice pool might not only include **Scout** but also an extra die for your **Nature** 6 specialty.

Specialities are free-form traits you create yourself. Specialities should never be as broad as roles; as a general rule, a specialty should apply to about a third as many situations as a basic role would (or less).

Though specialities are like more focused versions of roles, there are no limits on what role you must use to include a specialty that suits your action. Returning to the above example, if you show off your skill with a knife to intimidate someone into answering your questions, your pool might include both your **Speaker** role and an **Athletics** or **Weaponry** specialty.

Spheres

Magick is represented by ten spheres, acknowledged, even if begrudgingly and by different names, by all factions in the Awakened world.

Whenever you are creating a magickal effect you roll an appropriate Sphere.

If your effect requires multiple Spheres you must have all of them at the appropriate ranks, but you only roll one Sphere of your choice from those required.

- **Correspondence** the element of connection between apparently different things.
- **Entropy** the principle of chance, fate and mortality.
- **Forces** the understanding of elemental energies.
- **Life** the mysteries of life and death.
- **Matter** the principles behind supposedly "inanimate" objects.
- **Mind** the potentials of consciousness.
- **Prime** an understanding of the Primal Energy within all things.
- **Spirit** comprehension of Otherworldly forces and inhabitants.
- **Time** the strange workings of chronological forces and perceptions.

While those names are the ones understood by Traditions as the lingua franca of magic, every Faction has their own terminology and understanding for them, so you may feel free to rename the Spheres on your character sheet, so long as the rules themselves are maintained.

Ranks

Your magical capabilities are determined by your Sphere rating and are separated into five ranks of increasing power and complexity.

- Perception 6: An initiate grasps the essential principles and begins to perceive the ways in which that Sphere behaves. They can't alter anything just yet, but can put their observations to good use.
- Manipulation 8: The mage begins to use the Sphere to make small alterations in their local reality. Although not yet able to perform dramatic Effects, they gain a small degree of control over the Sphere's principles, but for many tasks, a small degree of control is all you need.
- Control 10: Achieving a greater level of accomplishment, the mage can make notable changes to elements connected with the Sphere. Remarkable feats become possible, and the mage approaches the realm of true wizardry.
- Command 12: An impressive command of the Sphere in question allows the mage to perform dramatic feats. Even when such Effects aren't obviously magick, they attain significant influence over the principles associated with that Sphere.
- Mastery 12 12: Magnificent feats become possible with such dominion within the Sphere. Literally godlike miracles greet the master of a Sphere, and Reality literally shapes itself to their whim.

The further explanations of magickal powers may be found later in the dedicated chapter on magick as describing them briefly is borderline impossible.

Spending Quintessence

With the weight of Paradox growing stronger as they pull on threads of reality, and side-effects of a spell gone awry any use of magick can take a toll on a mage, but sometimes you may chose to exert yourself further, expending some of your reserve of Quintessence to make your workings blaze with truth and power of creation. You can do so with ***Avatar Reserve*** SFX that every mage benefits from.

Avatar Reserve: Gain a PP, then take **Drained** 6 at the end of the current beat.

Recovering Quintessence

There are other, more specialised ways of regaining Quintessence, but every mage benefits from ***Channel Quintessence*** SFX.

Channel Quintessence: In a scene with a free source of quintessence, channel it to step down your **Drained**, then shut down this SFX. Activate an opportunity to recover.

Signature Assets

Signature assets are assets that have become permanent traits for a character, playing an ongoing and essential part in their story. Usually, they cover anything that gives you an advantage but isn't covered by your other trait sets.

Note that your signature assets do not include all of your character's gear or other advantages. When something is an asset, it just means that it's so important to your character's story that you gain an extra die when using it.

Most signature assets break down into one of five categories: things, creatures, places, people, and edges. Example signature assets for each category are listed below.

- *Things* are the most common form of signature asset, including items or equipment that you own, carry, or have access to. Examples include **Magic Carpet**, **1971 Dodge Challenger**, **Enchanted Dagger**, **My Family's Heirloom Sword**, **Divining Rod**, **Chainsaw**, etc.
- *Creatures* include pets, mounts, animal companions, familiars, and the like. Examples include **Racehorse**, **Well-Trained Cat**, **My Cat Snowball**, **Raven Familiar**, **Semi-Domesticated Wolf**, etc.
- *Places* represent advantages gained from being in or having knowledge of a certain location. Examples include **Seaside Hideout**, **Private Library**, **Special Forces Bar**, **Umbran Demesne**, **Hidden Glade**, **Panic Room**, **Basement Sanctum**, **Penthouse**, **Uncle's Army Surplus Store**, etc.
- *People* are minor STCs who can be relied upon to help you, at least occasionally. Examples include **My Apprentice**, **Hired Bodyguard**, **Blackmailed Senator**, **Master Mage Mentor**, **Fence Who Doesn't Ask Questions**, **Mob Informant**, **Witch Boyfriend**, **Psychic Little Sister**, etc.
- *Edges* are supernatural capabilities you can access via your magickal powers, such as psychic powers, exceptional senses, frequently-used spells, sacred rituals, or more powerful versions of the magickal powers available to every Awakened. Examples include **Mind Reading**, **Locator Spell**, **Telekinesis**, **Chain Lightning Rote**, **Ritual of Flame Immunity**, **Levitation**, **Fox Conjuration**, **Vorpal Claws**, **Fox Transformation**, etc. Anything that you and your ST agree suits your mage is fair game.

SFX

Each character has a handful of SFX, reflecting special capabilities associated with their Faction & Focus distinction as well as their Awakened nature. Whenever you gain an SFX or Limit that isn't specific to your Faction, you can rename it to better suit your character.

Non-stress complications named in SFX (such as **Over-Indulged** or **On Fire**) are mere suggestions and can always be swapped for something more creative or appropriate to the moment.

Some SFX are tagged as ***(Gear)***. These generally require you to have the equipment described in the SFX in order to use some or all of the options that SFX offers.

Limits

A Limit is a special type of SFX that imposes a disadvantage on your character in order to earn them PP or another reward.

Every PC has at least one Limit.

ST Activation

Unlike normal SFX, Limits can be activated by the ST as well as the player. Even when the ST does so, you still make all the choices and earn all the rewards listed for that Limit. For example, the ***We've Got History*** Limit lets you earn a PP by revealing that a STC was formerly your friend, ally, or lover. If the ST activates the Limit, you still decide whether the STC in question was your friend, or your ally, or your lover, and you still earn the PP. The Limit says you also take 6 **Demoralised** or **Enthralled** stress, but it is you who decides which of those two stresses you take, not the ST.

Reveals

Some Limits allow you to reveal information about the scene or setting. When you do so, your character explains a fact about the story that is true, a fact you create just like the ST would. Just as the ST might have a STC say "These thugs all have tattoos from the Cult of the Crimson Covenant", which establishes a truth about the world for everyone at the table, you have your character say something similar. Either way, the revelation changes the story, editing the narrative of your current scene to make the information you revealed true.

In the fiction of the game, what your character reveals is based on their existing knowledge or current observations. As a player at the table, however, you actually get to invent these new details for your character to share, creating new information that changes the story.

Some GMs and players prefer not to use these kinds of Limits. If your group doesn't want them, you can ignore Limits that call for player reveals.

All the Limits that explicitly require a player reveal are marked with an asterisk (*).

Character Creation

To create your neophyte mage character, you populate six trait sets – distinctions, attributes, roles, specialities, signature assets, and Spheres – and assign a die rating to each trait in those sets.

For traits like roles, when making a new character, you are given an array of die ratings for each set – such as 10, 8, 6, 6, 4 – and you assign one of these ratings to each trait in the set. So a character's roles might be Scholar 6, Scoundrel 4, Scout 10, Soldier 8, and Speaker 6.

When distributing these ratings, it is usually easiest to choose which of the traits is most significant, the one the character will rely on most and for which they would likely be most well-known to others. Assign the largest die rating to that one. Then choose their second best trait, one they are still really great with and can rely on, even if it isn't the most important one, and assign the second largest die rating to it. Then keep assigning in order from best to worst.

Character Creation: Distinctions

Define your character by writing in three distinctions, your Background, Faction, and Drive.

Each of your distinctions is rated 8.

For more inspiration when creating distinctions, including lists and optional die rolls, see Appendix A: Distinction Builder.

Character Creation: Attributes

Assign the either of the following die rating arrays to your six attributes, in any order:

- 10, 8, 8, 6, 6, 6,
- 8, 8, 8, 8, 6, 6
- or 10, 10, 8, 6, 6, 4.

Character Creation: Roles

Assign the following die ratings to your five roles, in any order: 10, 8, 6, 6, 4.

Character Creation: Specialities

The faction you belong to three specialities rated at 6 to your character.

Next you can choose add either two or three specialities to a new character. If you choose two, one is rated at 8 and the other is a 6 if you choose three, all three are rated at 6.

You can add a 6 to the bonus speciality to step it up to 8.

Character Creation: Spheres

The faction you belong to gives you a Sphere rated at 6.

In addition you choose to add either two or three Sphere ratings to your new character. If you choose two, one is rated at 8 and the other is 6 if you choose three, all three are rated at 6.

You can add a 6 to the bonus Sphere to step it up to 8.

Character Creation: Signature Assets

The faction you belong to adds a signature asset to your character.

Additionally you choose to add either two or three of these additional signature assets to your new character. If you choose two, one is rated at 8 and the other is 6 if you choose three, all three are rated at 6.

You can add a 6 to the signature asset gained from the Faction to step it up to 8.

Character Creation: SFX

Your character begins play with *Avatar Reserve* and *Channel Quintessence*, in addition to *Hinder*.

Character Creation: Limits

You choose and gain one Limit from those listed in Appendix B: SFX & Limits.

Character Creation: Milestones

All new characters start play with two milestones. Unless you and your ST agree on alternate milestones, you start with the default *Goal-Driven* and *Levelling Up* milestones listed below.

Milestone: Goal-Driven

- *1 XP* when you act to either affirm or conceal your commitment to a goal.
- *3 XP* when you recruit a new ally in pursuit of a goal or you betray or abandon allies to attain that goal.
- *10 XP* when defeating a challenge with at least one trait at 12 moves you closer to fulfilling a drive-related goal, or when you finally abandon a goal you've made sacrifices to pursue.

Milestone: Levelling Up

- *1 XP* when you earn a PP from an SFX or Limit (such as *Hinder*).
- *3 XP* when you help someone else recover from stress or you succeed on a roll to create an asset for an ally.
- *10 XP* when you recover from stress of 12 or larger, or when an asset you created for someone else helps defeat a challenge that has at least one trait at 12.

Character Creation: Bonus Enhancement

After all traits, SFX, and Milestones are set, choose just one of the following added bonus enhancements to make sure your character is as close as possible to your vision for them, then adjust your character accordingly:

- Add a new 6 specialty
- Add a new 6 signature asset
- Add a new 6 Sphere
- Upgrade a 6 specialty of your choice to 8
- Upgrade a 6 signature asset of your choice to 8
- Upgrade a 6 Sphere of your choice to 8
- Choose and gain one of the SFX listed in Appendix B: SFX & Limits.

Completing Your Character

Once you have determined and recorded your distinctions, attributes, roles, specialities, signature assets, Spheres, SFX, Limits, and milestones, you have all the mechanical elements of your character in place. If you haven't already, you need to choose your character's name and pronouns, and give them a description. Once this is done, your character is complete!

Factions

Choose one of the factions described in the following pages to define your character's alliances, training, and their place among their fellow mages.

During character creation a faction you choose grants your character a signature asset, three specialities of your choice from the list provided by the faction, one Sphere you choose from those provided, all rated at 6, as well as access to a list of faction SFX that your character can acquire more easily during character advancement than general SFX.

Though a faction does not grant a free SFX, during character creation you can use the bonus enhancement all PCs receive to gain one of your faction SFX.

Traditions

The Council of Ten Mystic Traditions, or simply the Traditions, are the default player characters and protagonists in the **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex**. The Traditions are a collection of magical traditions united by a common theory of magical Spheres, as well as a common purpose: the defence of magic and myth against the oppressive, static and safe Technocratic paradigm of predictability and control.

The council has traditionally maintained a seat for each Sphere, with certain Traditions (the Solificati and Ahl-i-Batin) leaving the council, only to be replaced by newer Traditions (the Sons of Ether and Virtual Adepts), and gain a new one with the introduction of the Death Sphere (Hollow Ones).

Akashayana/Akashic Brotherhood

The Akashic Brotherhood, also known as the Akashayana Sangha ("Order of the Vehicle of Akasha") or just the Akashayana, is a Tradition of mages masters of mind, body, and spirit pursuing the arts of personal discipline.

They believe that mind, body and spirit are all part of the larger whole of the person, just like at the same time that person is part of the whole of the universe. In other words, conflict, is an illusion, and the same can be said of identity and dispute, so when mind and body harmonize, the soul follows them. By honing their bodies, these mages make a temple for the mind that ultimately brings the comprehension of the spirit. The Brotherhood uses simple tools — exercise, meditation, practice and study — to refine the simple man into a brother of knowledge.

Focus

"Magick" is actually self-perfection and cosmic harmony. To master such Arts in the proper Way (Do), a person must expand awareness in all things, clarify thoughts, focus the body, and subdue emotional confusion. Asian alchemy, craftwork, faith, yoga, social dominion, and martial arts training allow a Brother to channel life energy (*chi*) toward astounding feats of physical, mental, and energetic achievement.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A person who helped you significantly along the path of enlightenment
Bonus Specialities	Awareness Esoterica Martial Arts Meditation
Affinity Sphere	Mind, or Life
Faction SFX	

Celestial Chorus

The Celestial Chorus is a Tradition of mages united by their efforts to touch the Divine as well as their belief in the One and Prime from which all things originate.

Closely tied to the God of Abrahamic faiths (although its beliefs actually originate from the Ancient Egyptian monotheistic god Aten), the One represents the source of all Creation and all Creation is believed to be a part of the One. Humans in particular carry shards of the divine within them, though it is known by many names: the divine flame, the soul, the Avatar. It is this connection which the Celestial Chorus believes enables them to clearly hear the One's song and to shape Creation.

While their faith is essentially monotheistic, it is accepted that the Divine has many facets , so members of many faiths and denominations (including a variety of soft polytheists) come together in worship and service of the One, accepting that each person has their own path to the One, despite the Singers' history of martyrs, holy wars, division and compromise, sacrifice and resurrection.

Focus

The Arts flow not from personal achievement or intent but from faith, unity, and harmony with the Divine Will. Singing – especially many voices joined in harmony – provides this Tradition's oldest and most important instrument. Chorister magick tends to manifest in light, fire, warmth, harmonic vibrations, and sublime music. Faith and High Ritual form the core of Celestial Chorus practices.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An object or a place that is instrumental to your faith
Bonus Specialities	**Ceremony** **Empathy** **Music** **Theology**
Affinity Sphere	**Prime**, **Forces**, or **Spirit**
Faction SFX	*Abjure the Unholy* *Acolyte Militant* *Aura of Faith* *Blessed Orator* *Divine Providence*

Cult of Ecstasy/Sahajiya

The Cult of Ecstasy (also known as Sahajiya, a term derived from the Sanskrit word Sahaja which literally means spontaneous or natural) is a Tradition of mages and visionary seers who transcend boundaries and limitations through sacred experience.

To achieve that, the Cult uses things like drugs, music and sex, but they are just means to an end. The objective is to achieve a mental state that transcends the physical world, a trance that allows the mage to see beyond his normal experience and go outside all the lines that keep most people and mages penned in. Cultists take the word ecstasy in its original meaning: a sudden, intense rush of feeling that catapults the subject into an altered state. It does not have to be a pleasant feeling, but given a choice, most Cultists definitely prefer it that way. The Cult of Ecstasy breaks down barriers and self-imposed limitations to give people a rush of eye-opening experience.

Focus

"Get out of your own way" sums up the Ecstatic paradigm. To touch the Lakashim ("Divine Pulse"), a person must blow open the doors of inhibition and fear. Magick is the communion between a focused mind and the Lakashim – a dance of possibilities directed by crazy wisdom. To perform it, an Ecstatic guides life force with conscious but flexible intentions. Ideally, a mage operates in a flux state in which neither time nor inhibitions block the life force – aware of what they're doing and yet open enough to do anything.

The Cult's infamous substances and stimulations are meant to blast away any obstacles to Enlightenment, at least in theory. In reality, those same tools can become obstacles in their own right. Smart Ecstatics, then, keep shifting their tools around to avoid stagnation and constraints. Crazy wisdom is the core of this group's many practices, which include everything from gutter magick, yoga, and martial arts to cybernetic hypertech.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A place that helps you to unshackle yourself from the earthly drudgery
Bonus Specialities	**Artistry** **Awareness** **Empathy** **Pharmaceuticals**
Affinity Sphere	**Time**, **Life**, or **Mind**
Faction SFX	

Dreamspeakers/Kha'vadi

The Dreamspeakers (also known as Kha'vadi) are a Tradition of mages consisting of individuals who practice shamanism, communing with spirits as part of their magic and existing as intermediaries between the Mortal World and the Spirit World.

It is one of the most diverse Traditions, with those representing the ancient cultures of African, Native American, Inuit, and Aboriginal Australian societies standing alongside practitioners of Shinto, independent spiritual savants, and descendants of other forgotten tribes and civilizations. Though originally shoehorned into a single group by the other, Eurocentric Traditions, the disparate cultures within the Dreamspeakers have found common ground in their respect for and dedication to the balance between physical and spiritual reality.

As the Gauntlet has grown thicker and the Spirit World more dangerous, the shamans' duties have become increasingly harder. But whereas other mages tend to overlook matters of spirit and Sleepers forget them altogether, the Dreamspeakers were born to walk the middle ground; to see and hear what others do not, and to fill roles still very much needed in the modern world.

Focus

Medicine, not magick, is the essence of Dreamspeaker Arts. An avatar is Howahkan: the mysterious voice that speaks to those who are ready to hear it. Sorcery is an egotistical and ultimately destructive Path that leads people away from the Good Road of harmony with the World Spirit. To reach past the illusions of mortal life, one must listen to Creation's heartbeat, face death, and remain open to the voice through which all life speaks.

Practice-wise, 'Speakers favour medicine-work, craftwork, shamanism, crazy wisdom, and faith. A few pursue cybernetics, yoga, Voudoun, and witchcraft, but their companions often shun them.

Faction Bonus

Bonus Asset	An item that a spirit companion of yours elected to inhabit making it a Fetish.
Bonus Specialities	Etiquette Herbalism Mysticism Technology
Affinity Sphere	Spirit, Forces, Life, or Matter
Faction SFX	*Dimensional Vagabond* *Embolden the Spirits* *One of Their Own* *Quell The Spirits* *Storied History*

Euthanatoi/Chakravanti

The Euthanatoi, also known as the Chakravanti ("People of the Wheel") or the Niyamavanti ("People of our Rule") are a Tradition of mages intimately devoted to the forces of death, rebirth, destiny, and karma in the world. They represent a collection of thanatotic cultists, necromancers, priests of fate, assassins, scholars, gamblers and healers.

Euthanatos mages embrace the role of death in the world as that which cleanses and makes way for future growth. Most believe in the reincarnation of souls, meaning death in one life is not to be feared and in fact may be crucial to one's spiritual development. Even those who do not share this belief recognize a continuous cycle of death and rebirth throughout life, and accept that at times death may be necessary to end suffering. These mages guard the moment between life and death. Guardians of reincarnation, they see Creation as a spinning Wheel of Death and Rebirth. When something, or someone, interferes with it, the obstacle should be removed. The method of removal may be as simple as a kind word or as final as murder.

Most controversially, many Euthanatos see it as their duty to push this cycle forward, removing sources of disease, corruption, and misery from the world in order to quicken the turn of the Wheel of Ages. This means judging when a person's moral degradation has grown too harmful to themselves or others to be allowed to continue, and when it is appropriate to deliver the Good Death.

Euthanatos are not cavalier about this responsibility, and are painfully aware of the risks, but they know their work is necessary and that they are the only ones for it. To the Euthanatoi, their duty is sacred, one that must be carried out, but is so strenuous and terrible that only the most strong-willed can perform it. It is not so much that they take on a right, as they take on a burden: responsibility for pain, for release and for renewal.

Focus

As masters of life, death, Fate, and Fortune, the Euthanatoi view magick as an extension of the Cycle. By turning the Wheel, these mages control probability as well as the forces of mortality. That turning focuses on the cyclical nature of existence, and so a Chakravat uses practices and instruments like crazy wisdom, faith, High Ritual, medicine-work, reality hacking, martial arts, shamanism, and occasionally Voudoun to direct those energies toward the desired end. Yoga has an essential place in this Tradition's Arts.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A weapon or any other tool of choice you use to carry out your morbid responsibilities
Bonus Specialities	**Esoterica** **Firearms** **Medicine** **Subterfuge**
Affinity Sphere	**Death**, **Life**, or **Fate**
Faction SFX	

Hollow Ones

The Hollow Ones is the Tradition of castaways of modern society, those who reject establishment and the flawed order it brings, united by the ideals of Art and True Romance, but disparate in its forms.

Long considered a Lost Tradition, the Hollow Ones dwell in the underbelly of the world, among the undesirables and dregs who couldn't find purchase elsewhere, in societies both mundane and hidden. These Hollow Men focus on earthly matters, rejecting the notions of Ascension that the world of Awakened finds itself bogged down in. It is no surprise then that the Tradition lacks any kind of centralised Paradigm, instead using whatever mystic practice they can get their hands of, modifying or deliberately bastardising them in the process. No Hollow One is alike, expressing their void in their own way and in this they find unity of purpose.

Focus

Darklings use whatever they've got to work with – typically things discarded by society. Broken toys, occult goodies, and symbols and behaviors that so-called respectable people shun make potent tools in the hands of a Hollow mage. Belief-wise, that hollow image is appropriately symbolic: these folks tend to see themselves as vessels of life and death, pouring their Arts out or carrying those cosmic forces from place to place. Magick, then, comes from the proper comprehension and intentional use of the energies that, in most people, are simply wasted. Chaos and gutter magick are near-universal among the Hollow Ones. Although such Arts don't actually nurture chaos, they thrive in the chaos of our age.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An object taken from an established magickal practice that you use in your Willworking
Bonus Specialities	**Artistry** **Occultism** **Streetwise** **Subterfuge**
Affinity Sphere	**Fate**, **Death** or **Forces**
Faction SFX	

Order of Hermes

The Order of Hermes is one of the pillars of the Traditions. A Fellowship during the Dark Ages, it draws upon a potent fundus of magical knowledge and has shaped occult history to great deals.

Its failings, however, are equally grand. Hubris runs strong within the elitist Order, and with the Reckoning, many of their traditional ways are challenged. Old, carefully hoarded secrets are gone forever in many cases, while mystical items and powerful patrons are destroyed or locked away beyond the hostile Gauntlet. The survivors on Earth can only hope to remember their teachings and learn all that they can. The Order will survive, but it may not be the same Order that it once was.

Focus

A Hermetic mage commands nothing less than the keys to the universe. And so, these consummate scholars master ancient and arcane rituals through constant study and intense practice. Tapping elemental currents through incantations, signs, seals, paraphernalia, and secret languages, the Hermetics are – by necessity – secretive and suspicious. They command tremendous power, after all, and their rivals lurk everywhere.

Alchemy, dominion, and High Ritual form core practices within the Order's ranks. No Hermetic mage lacks such training. Certain Hermetics add chaos magick, the Art of Desire, hypertech, craftwork, weird science, yoga, and occasional maleficia to that core.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An effect that can be produced by any Sphere at
Bonus Specialities	**Academics** **Etiquette** **Ritual** **Science**
Affinity Sphere	**Forces** or any other Sphere appropriate for your House
Faction SFX	*Conjured Elemental* *Prepared Caster* *Rote Memorization* *Erudite Researcher (Gear)* *Rods, Staves, & Wands (Gear)*

Society of Ether/Sons of Ether

The Sons of Ether (renamed the Society of Ether in the Modern Nights) are a group of technomancers aligned to the Council of Ten. Originally part of the Order of Reason and the Technocracy, they abandoned their former compatriots after the Union aided the expulsion of the Luminiferous Ether from the Consensus. Since then, the Sons have adopted several outdated technologies and incorporated them into their Paradigm.

Focus

Science! Or, more accurately, an imaginative grasp of natural principles channeled through established physical and energetic technologies. Earthier than their Virtual Adept colleagues, these technomancers prefer to employ Science that can be seen, held, demonstrated, and confirmed even by the eyes of fools. To that end, Etherite Science is showy, romantic, and gracefully futuristic, even if that future looks more like classic science fiction than like mundane science fact.

As a practice, an Etherite may use anything that seems to work. Most Scientists, however, favor gloriously esoteric variations on alchemy, craftwork, cybernetics, hypertech, reality hacking, and, of course, weird science.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A place where you conduct your research and create your marvellous devices safe from Consensus infringement
Bonus Specialities	**Academics** **Cosmology** **Craft** **Technology**
Affinity Sphere	**Matter**, **Forces**, or **Prime**
Faction SFX	***Trust Me, I'm an Engineer*** ***It's Gonna Blow*** ***How It's Made*** ***Auxiliary Operational Mode (Gear)*** ***We Need More Funding***

Verbena

The Verbena is a Tradition of mages dedicated to preserving the ancient crafts and wisdom passed down over the ages by witches and warlocks, druids and druidesses, mystics, and priests and priestesses of the Old Gods.

Though modern Verbena have some similarities to Wiccans, they are inheritors of far older legacies from disparate cultures originating around the world. Regardless of their many differing faiths and customs, the Verbena share many principles in common. This includes a deep respect for the Earth and the natural order, a holistic view of people and the world as intrinsically intertwined, and the belief that power and understanding can be found by embracing life in all its passions and pains.

Of all the Traditions, the Verbena are perhaps most challenged by the changes brought to the world by advancing technology and expanding civilizations. Each member must find a way to apply the lessons and practices of the old ways to the modern world, or be seen by both mages and mortals as merely a fringe practitioner of a dying craft.

Focus

Verbena Arts concentrate on doing a lot with very little. Their tools are practical as well as symbolic, with uses that reach back to antiquity. "Pagan" in every sense of that word, these magicks hold deep ties to Nature. Shape-changing, transformation, healing and injury, divination, purification, growth and withering, natural cycles, and the tricky ways of Fate are witch-folk specialities.

Witchcraft is the group's core practice, with certain individuals favouring Voudoun, dominion, weird science, chaos magick, yoga, martial arts, High Ritual, cybernetics, the Art of Desire, craftwork, medicine-work, and even organic hypertech.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An animal that is inhabited by a spirit with whom you are bound with in a familiar connection
Bonus Specialities	**Animal Ken** **Brawl** **Herbalism** **Survival**
Affinity Sphere	**Life** or **Forces**
Faction SFX	*Balm* *Beastform* *Claws & Fangs* *Healing Touch* *Oak & Mistletoe*

Virtual Adepts/Mercurial Elite

The Virtual Adepts (also known as the Mercurial Elite) are the second youngest members of the Traditions, already alienated from the Technocracy after the second World War for their nonconformity the execution of their ideological leader, an elite mathematician mage Alan turing they defected to the Traditions. Focused on the Digital Web, the Adepts search for a way to reach the singularity, the point where mankind can transcend into something post-human.

Digital anarchists, hackers of reality and technology, brilliant mathematicians and many more, they are some of the biggest enemies of Technocracy. Virtual Adepts are the ones who subvert and take apart the systems under Technocratic control to learn their function and and counter them.

Focus

Every tool or practice an Adept employs focuses on shaping, altering, manipulating, gathering, storing, collating, influencing, or destroying information. Such tools range from the obvious computer gear (generations ahead of conventionally available tech), clouds, holograms, implants, nanotech, energy drinks, and sense-altering stimuli to the understated chic of dark hoodies, manga-influenced haircuts, fashionable androgyny, and provocative masks. All Adepts, however, keep the implements of their technomagick handy. For many Adepts, computers are a more important part of one's identity than any attire or accessory. An Adept's personal devices are almost always the most heavily customized and stylized elements of that Adept's ensemble.

Perhaps the most accomplished reality hackers alive, this Mercurial Elite also employs various forms of cybernetics, hypertech, weird science, martial arts, chaos magick, gutter magick, and sometimes shamanism, Voudoun, crazy wisdom, or witchcraft with a technological flair.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An informational system that you have access to and use for reality hacking
Bonus Specialities	**Computer** **Enigmas** **Streetwise** **Technology**
Affinity Sphere	**Correspondence** or **Forces**
Faction SFX	

Technocracy

The Technocratic Union, or the Technocracy (also called the Hidden Ones or the Five Metal Dragons) are the bitter rival and enemy of the Traditions.

They were initially founded as the Order of Reason in 1325, a group dedicated to the protection of humanity from the depredations of the supernatural – specifically Mages, and more specifically the Order of Hermes.

Now the Technocratic Union enforces global order under their Enlightened guidance and protection. Dedicated to wiping out Reality Deviants, they've spent over 500 years at war with the mystic Traditions, wonder and nonconformity.

Iteration X

The Iteration X are engineers, technicians, inventors, and the mighty production forge of the Technocracy. Experts in technology that is beyond any scientific understanding of the Masses, they use advanced theories of physics, hypertech, AI to expand the boundaries of inorganic sciences, and improve the human condition with the cold, calculated efficiency of steel, microchip, and cybernetic implant.

Focus

The core of Iteration X science comes from the synergy between organic, mechanical, social, mathematical, and psychological elements. And so, cybernetics, craftwork and hypertech forge the foundation of this group's practices. Innovative Iterators employ martial arts, social dominion, hypereconomics, and reality hacking – after all, even perfection must be flexible! A few even hold a demi-religious faith in the ultimate potential of The Machine; these days, though, they don't often discuss that out loud.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A hypertech Device that you created or integrated into your body
Bonus Specialities	**Craft** **Cybernetics** **Science** **Technology**
Affinity Sphere	**Forces**, **Matter** or **Time**
Faction SFX	

New World Order

The New World Order, often shortened to N.W.O., are the secret police force within the Technocracy, dedicated on shaping and guiding information in progress with the Collective Will of the Masses. The New World Order is responsible for much of processing of Reality Deviants and advancing the goals of the Time Table.

Focus

Social dominion and the command of consciousness – that is, the influence, harnessing, programming, and reprogramming of the homo sapiens mind – provides the cornerstone of this New World Order's techniques. To that end, psychic training, information manipulation, perceptual conditioning, and symbolic connections (like a man wearing a formal black suit and carrying a badge) provide the essential tools for NWO Procedures. Physical media constitute the second level of manipulation, with the third and most brutal level – force – channelled through guns, armour, gadgets, hypertech vehicles, advanced weaponry, and the martial arts training all operatives receive. Paranoia, however, is the Order's strongest weapon. If people believe you can do something, after all, their belief tilts reality in your favour before you even begin to act.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	An item that represents your legal authority
Bonus Specialities	Enigmas Law Manipulation Melee
Affinity Sphere	Mind or Correspondence
Faction SFX	*Requisitions*

Progenitors

The Progenitors are doctors and medicians within the Technocracy, dedicating themselves to biological sciences. Masters of the Sphere of Life, they employ the tools of genetic manipulation, hyper-advanced surgical techniques and sophisticated drugs to constantly push the envelope of medicine. They sometimes work closely with Iteration X, especially in the fields of cybertechnology and artificial body parts.

Focus

The intricate enigmas and potential of organic life provide the foundation of Progenitor techniques. Upon that framework, an individual Progenitor can build a wide variety of innovations. Although specific applications must be scientifically defensible (even if extremely loosely so), the Progenitors employ a dizzying variety of theories and Procedures. That said, those weird science techniques typically demand the presence of a well-stocked lab and intricate, often time-consuming, labour. Any tool that a healer, scientist, or naturalist would use can yield miraculous results in the skilful hands of a trained Technocrat, but the Progenitors usually need time and space to work their miracles.

Cybernetics blend in with a hypertech approach to medicine-work, and the Convention's eclectic methods often seem like weird science by the standards of other Conventions.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A biological modification that assists your experiments, which you developed during training
Bonus Specialities	Academics Medicine Pharmaceuticals Science
Affinity Sphere	Life or Prime
Faction SFX	

Syndicate

A political bloc-turned-Convention, the Syndicate is one of the most reviled Conventions, even within the Technocracy. They control the flow of money and trade among the Masses as well as in the Union. This leaves them in a very unpopular position and they are often blamed for perceived shortcomings. The Syndicate knows, however, that they are the glue which keeps the Union together and that the Technocracy could not function without them.

Focus

Ars Cupiditae, the Art of Desire, provides the heart of Syndicate methodology. Refined by the High Guild during the medieval period, this portfolio of techniques focuses on self-mastery and social psychology. Essentially, the practitioner disciplines his own body and mind, refines relationship techniques, and establishes a kingdom around himself that he gradually expands into an empire of subtle but compelling influence.

Except in the most desperate circumstances, a Syndicate rep never resorts to vulgar Procedures; even then, those Adjustments employ high-tech weapons, martial arts, or other stylishly technological methods. Most often, a Syndicate Associate manipulates people and systems with subtle yet effective nudges – phone calls, bribes, handshakes, perfumes, seductions, power lunches, PowerPoint presentations, hypereconomics, social domination, and so on – that get other people to pull the trigger while the Associate tallies up the profits.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A business that you have appropriated as a Primal Venture
Bonus Specialities	**Finances** **Law** **Leadership** **Subterfuge**
Affinity Sphere	**Entropy**, **Mind**, or **Prime**
Faction SFX	

Void Engineers

Explorers of wild frontiers on earth and beyond it, Void Engineers are cataloguing, taming, and assimilating the discovered dimensions into a safely controlled cosmos for the Masses to exist in. The Void Engineers, in addition to being dimensional scientists and explorers, are the first line of defence the Technocracy puts between humanity and the horrors man was not meant to know.

Focus

As every Engineer knows, only Tech Holds All Answers in A World of Gods and Monsters. Without imposed order, Everything is Chaos. And so, hypertech melds with cybernetics, craftwork, cosmic reality hacking, and a formalized type of weird science.

Mind-bending quantum physics, and the machines created to channel those physics, form the core of Wanderer beliefs. To that end, they adapt alien technologies and sanitized versions of ancient spiritual Arts, incorporated through reconciliation theories that bind those ideas and energies to scientific methods. In the Realms beyond Earth's limited reality sphere, Void Engineer technologies have all the subtlety of a big-budget science-fiction film. Blasters slide out of holsters, power-armour suits become essential, and titanic Universal craft (that is, spaceships) are the order of the day.

Faction Bonuses

Bonus Asset	A Device that shields you from a particular hazardous environment and assists in employing Enlightened procedures
Bonus Specialities	Cosmology Firearms Survival Technology
Affinity Sphere	Spirit, Correspondence , or Forces
Faction SFX	

Magick

Evolving Characters

During play, your character will change. Some changes will be temporary; others will last the rest of your character's career.

Milestones

As you play, your character can gain Experience Points (XP), which can be used to change or augment your traits. You earn XP using milestones, lists of actions or events that advance your character's story and give them a chance to grow.

A character has two milestones at a time. A milestone usually has three levels, each of which provides a different amount of XP and can be tapped for XP at certain times:

- A ***1 XP*** level that you can hit once per beat;
- A ***3 XP*** level that you can hit once per scene;
- And a ***10 XP*** level that you can hit once per session.

Once XP is gained, it can be spent between sessions to change or improve your traits, gain new traits, or unlock other benefits. After you complete the 10 XP level, you remove that milestone and replace it, starting a brand new milestone.

(Theoretically, you could choose to send your character on a new version of the same journey by starting the same milestone over again, if you feel it captures an aspect of your character that you'd like to explore more deeply, but it's usually more interesting to move on to a new one.)

Changing Milestones

By default, once you hit the 10 XP level of a milestone, the entire milestone is closed; after the session ends, the closed milestone is replaced with a new one. (In some cases, the ST may allow this "replacement" to just be a fresh copy of the milestone.)

New milestones can be created in collaboration by the player and ST, or chosen from those listed in Appendix C: Sample Milestones.

Spending XP

Once experience points are earned via Milestones, they can then be spent for the benefit of your character. **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** uses the following table for the most common uses of Experience Points:

Spend 1 XP to:

- Start the next game session with one extra PP. (You can't start a game session with more than 5 PPs.)

Spend 3 XP to do one of the following:

- Replace an existing distinction with a new one.
- Add or replace a Limit.
- Add a new 4 specialty or signature asset
- Upgrade an existing specialty or signature asset from 4 to 6.

Spend 5 XP to do one of the following:

- Add a new 6 specialty.
- Convert a temporary asset into a 6 signature asset.
- Replace an existing SFX with a new one.

Spend 10 XP to do one of the following:

- Upgrade a 4 role to 6.
- Add a new signature asset rated at 6.
- Upgrade an existing 6 specialty or signature asset to 8.
- Add a new Sphere rated at 6.

Spend 15 XP to do one of the following:

- Upgrade a 6 role to 8.
- Upgrade an existing 8 specialty or signature asset to 10.
- Add a new faction SFX.
- Upgrade a 6 Sphere to 8.

Spend 20 XP to do one of the following:

- Upgrade a 8 role to 10.
- Upgrade an existing 10 specialty or signature asset to 12.
- Upgrade a 8 Sphere to 10.

Spend 25 XP to:

- Upgrade a 10 role to 12.
- Upgrade a 10 Sphere to 12.

Spend 30 XP to:

- Add a new SFX from a Faction you are not a part of.

ST Rules

There's more to STing a game than learning the rules, but assuming you've got a handle on the basics, there are a few extra rules the ST needs to know in order to run **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** games.

Scene Framing

Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex gives players a lot of power over their characters and what happens to them. The ST isn't an omnipotent narrator, just another player with specialized responsibilities, portraying the world and the creatures in it rather than one special character of their own. However, one major power the ST possesses is that they are the one who frames scenes.

To frame a new scene, the ST makes decisions based on the story so far. They determine where it happens, who is present, and what is already happening when the PCs arrive.

While you might have a rough plan, avoid all expectations as to how a scene might end or what the player will choose to do. Include elements you think will spur the PCs into action, but the goal isn't to move players along a predetermined track; play to find out what happens.

Scene Distinctions

Each scene can be framed with up to three scene distinctions, special traits that any character in the scene can include in their rolls (if a character has distinctions of their own, their player chooses whether to use a scene distinction or one of their character distinctions for each roll). Scene distinctions are rated at ◆8, and can be used to earn plot points with *Hinder*.

As a special rule, a character can include both a personal distinction and a scene distinction in the same roll, as long as one of the two distinctions is *Hindered*.

Scale

Sometimes, a creature or other part of the story differs from the player characters in power or size so dramatically that it commands an innate advantage (or disadvantage, if it is smaller or weaker). When necessary, an extra trait known as scale is assigned.

Scale ranges from d4 to d12. Most mages, Night Folk and humans, as well as most humans and animals, have a scale of d6. Master mages and elder Night Folk have a scale of d8. A creature with a higher scale isn't just larger or more powerful – it is *many times* larger or more powerful. In the film version of *The Fellowship of the Ring*, the heroes' long fight against the cave troll is a desperate one, because of the creature's massive superiority of scale (d8 compared to the Fellowship members' d6). In the later film in the series, *The Return of the King*, the Witch-King of Angmar is also of greater scale – not because of his size, but because his level of power is beyond mortal ken.

When a character or other part of the story rolls against a PC of a different scale, the one with the greater scale includes their scale die in their dice pool. In addition, when you are the one with the greater scale, after you roll, you keep three dice to add together for your total, instead of just two. Obviously, this is a very powerful advantage.

A d4 scale is likely never going to be rolled (since there is no lower rating), but it exists to represent creatures with a level of power or size far beneath the scale of normal humans. A small child or animal, or a similarly smaller and/or weaker creature, would have a d4 scale. As a result, a PC would add a d6 scale die to its rolls against such a creature, though in general the ST shouldn't bother having a PC make such a roll.

Spending Peril Dice

The ST can remove dice from the peril pool, "spending" them for a number of uses during play, including:

As plot points: The ST can spend a die to obtain the same benefits for their STCs that a player gets for spending PP for their PC.

To add dice to a roll: Before a die roll is made, the ST can remove one or more peril dice from their pool, then add those die to the roll.

For surprise entrances: To introduce a new STC to a scene mid-conflict, the ST can spend a peril die equal to the new STC's highest trait.

For sudden changes: The ST can add a new scene distinction mid-scene by spending a 8 or higher.

To interrupt the action order: When a player would take a turn, the ST can have a STC or challenge take their turn first by spending a peril die. This only works if the die spent is equal to or larger than the **Scout** trait of the character the ST is interrupting.

To split the PC group: The ST can spend a 10 or larger peril die to announce a sudden event that divides the party (such as a sudden building collapse, a huge crack opening in the street, a massive car crash, etc.)

To immediately end the current scene with dramatic twist The ST has the power to end scenes. However, if they want to end the scene in a cliffhanger or defeat for the PCs, or in a similarly dramatic fashion that the PCs might otherwise try to prevent, the ST can do so by spending 12 12.

Storyteller Characters (STCs)

To help you make sure you don't do more work than necessary when creating STCs, the rules divide them into different types depending on the role you expect them to fulfil in the story.

Storyteller Characters

Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex presents a world where mortals live in relative peace, but the secret world of the mages and Night Folk is full of conflict and dangerous rivalries. During a session, some STCs are meant to be challenging opposition, but others are bit parts and recurring secondary characters, so there are different ways of creating STCs.

STCs are split into three different types depending on the role you expect them to fulfil in the story: Extras, Analog STCs, and Challenge Pools.

Extras can be created as needed during play. Analog STCs and Challenge Pools work best for recurring characters who harry the player characters across multiple adventures. These may start as Extras or as Boss challenge pools; you can switch their type between sessions, and even use them as an Analog STC for a few adventures and then turn them into a Boss for a final showdown.

Extras

An extra is a nameless character in a scene who has just one trait describing their role in the story, like **Bored Cop** 10 or **Suspicious Neighbour** 6. This trait is added to other dice pools (such as the peril pool) rather than rolled on its own. When extras take a complication or stress larger than their trait die, they are taken out. Most extras are invented during play rather than created in advance.

Analog STCs

These are created much the same way you'd make a player character, although they can be simplified from that format. For example, instead of defining every trait in a trait set, they might only have the traits they are likely to use. Analog STCs may have whatever number of SFX or Limits seem appropriate (though generally not more than the ST can easily keep track of). They are taken out with stress or complications in the same way as a PC.

As Challenge Pools

A challenge pool is something the PCs have to deal with, and not only can it represent a STC, but also a hazard, dilemma, crisis, or anything else that could be an obstacle to the characters' progress. Challenge pools are the basic building blocks of **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** adventures, and they are described in their own section.

Upgrading STCs

If a STC's importance grows beyond initial expectations, you can always switch their type between sessions as the developing story requires. You can even convert a STC into a challenge pool or vice-versa.

STCs and Dice Pools

When a PC rolls a test where a STC might interfere with or oppose that roll, the ST can add one or more STC traits to the peril pool before rolling. If a PC acts directly against an analog STC or challenge pool, the ST usually builds a dice pool based on traits just as a PC would and rolls that as opposition, instead of rolling the peril pool.

Challenge Pools

A challenge pool represents a complex and difficult situation that requires sustained effort to overcome, rather than any single action. It can represent any crisis or series of obstacles the PCs face: a forest fire, breaking into a vault, escaping police pursuit, dispelling complex magical wards, rescuing people from a collapsing structure, steering a raft down rocky rapids, negotiating the various rivalries and agendas at a social event, etc. Powerful foes or groups of enemies can also be represented by challenge pools.

Challenge pools are the basic structure around which **Mage: The Ascension Primed by Cortex** adventures are built. A handful of challenge pools (including bunch of mobs, and one or two bosses, as described in this section) is all you need to tell a compelling story that lasts for an entire session.

The core of every challenge is a pool of dice that the players will step down and remove as they address the situation. This is its Challenge trait. The challenge remains a driving element of the story until the last die is removed from its pool.

Opposing The Challenge Pool

Player characters can use their action to reduce the challenge pool. When they do so, the entire challenge pool is rolled as a reaction against them. Usually, a PC tries to reduce the challenge pool by inflicting some kind of complication or stress on it.

However, challenge pools don't actually gain complications or stress, nor do they gain assets. Whenever a PC would inflict stress or a complication on a challenge pool, the player instead compares their effect die to a challenge pool die of their choice. If the complication or stress is bigger than that die, that die leaves the pool. If it isn't, the chosen die steps down. Similarly, whenever a challenge pool would gain an asset, that asset immediately converts into a new challenge die instead. When the last challenge die is removed, the challenge is defeated.

Trying to reduce a challenge pool is risky, however. Failing a roll to do so inflicts stress on the PC, just as failing a test would, but instead of a 6, the ST can choose to inflict the challenge pool's effect die as stress.

Also, when a player hitches against a challenge pool, instead of giving the player a PP, the ST may spend a die from the pool's challenge trait to turn the hitched die into a complication on the PC.

Challenge Pool Actions

The PCs face challenge pools in action order, and once every PC has had a turn, the challenge pool gets a turn as well. Usually, it rolls to inflict stress or create a complication, but it can also roll to create an asset for itself (which becomes a new challenge die).

Instead of rolling, the challenge can use its turn to step up its smallest die or grant the ST a PP. The ST narrates how the challenge escalates or worsens, and then play moves on.

Finally, the ST can use the pool's turn to spend a die from the challenge trait and move a PC's complication to the challenge pool to replace it. The PC no longer has the complication, but the problem they were dealing with is now everybody's problem! (Obviously, the optimal use of this move by the ST would be replacing a smaller die with a larger one.)

STCs Vs Challenges?

If a challenge pool works against a STC, or vice-versa, or if STCs work against each other, the ST has two choices. They can let a PC roll determine the outcome, or they can simply decide what happens. GMs never roll dice against themselves.

Building Challenges

The ST creates the challenge pool by choosing three to six dice of the same size, from 6 to 12. Die size describes difficulty, while the number of dice roughly determines how long the challenge will last.

A 6 6 6 challenge pool will probably be quick and easy, while a pool of 12 12 12 12 12 is likely to be long and difficult.

If you wish, you can also give a challenge pool other traits or SFX, just like a STC, but that isn't necessary if you'd rather keep things simple for yourself during play.

Mobs

A mob is a challenge pool variant representing a group of opposing characters or creatures: a pack of werewolves, a gang of thugs, anti-government terrorists, rioting cops, summoned demons, etc. A mob's challenge pool is called its Mob Dice and this trait sometimes gets a colourful name.

Instead of stepping down its dice, mobs take complications like STCs. When a complication steps up past the Mob Trait's die size, the mob loses a die from that trait and the complication is eliminated. When Mob Trait loses its last die, it is taken out.

A mob also has signature assets in addition to its mob dice (like those of a minor STC), which it can add to its rolls. Mobs can also have SFX, and most have at least one SFX like ***All-Out Attack***, ***Area Spell***, or ***Impossible to Ignore*** that allow the mob to target multiple characters on its action.

Bosses

A boss is a variation that represents one STC meant to challenge multiple PCs at once. A boss works exactly like a mob except that instead of a Mob Dice trait, it has Boss Dice trait.

Organization

A organization works much like a mob, but it is a much larger group operating on a level beyond what any single individual (even a mage) can do. Secret societies, military forces, spy networks, organized crime, oligarch families, corporations, covert rebellions, insidious cults, police forces, and occult conspiracies are examples of organizations. An organization possesses a scale trait of 8 or higher, giving it a powerful advantage when acting against the PCs. An organization has an Org Dice trait just like a mob has a Mob Dice trait.

Levelling Challenges

Tailoring dice ratings is more art than science. A challenge pool with fewer dice takes less time than a challenge pool with more. A challenge pool of larger dice will take more time still and will also require the PCs to tap more resources and push harder to bring down those dice. Larger ratings of signature assets, which rarely change, make the challenge harder still.

Additionally, the player characters may have traits and SFX that make them more effective against specific threats. A ghost-hunting exorcist is going to defeat a mob of poltergeists much faster than they would an equally-rated mob of well-armed mercenaries on the hunt, whereas a veteran Flambeau wizard armed with his amulets and wand will have a much easier time dispatching the mercenaries.

The best way to crack this chestnut is play. Throw a 6 6 6 6 6 mob at the players, followed by a 8 8 8 8 challenge, and then a 10 10 10 boss. Jot down notes as to how quickly they go down. Iterate for the next adventure. You will very shortly develop a good sense, not only of how long and difficult any given encounter will play out, but how well it fits into your friends' expectations of play and attention spans.

Sample STCs and Challenge Pools

These are some example enemies, allies, and challenges that you can use in your games. STCs and Challenge Pools can also be a useful shortcut to creating an adventure. Come up with a handful of these, figure out a situation that weaves them together and makes life tough for the PCs, and you pretty much have what you need to run a game session.

The dice in each challenge's main trait (like its mob trait or boss trait) are just a suggestion, which you should feel empowered to change. Part of the ST's job is deciding what die ratings to assign to challenge pools in order to best tailor the challenge to PCs.

Militia Leader's Bunker (Challenge Pool)

Hideout for incendiary insurgents and inconsistent ideologies.

POOL: **Fortified Compound** 10 10 10

Too Many Guns 6

Special Forces Rejects 4

All-Out Attack: Spend a PP to target multiple opponents when you roll to inflict **Damaged**. For each additional target, add 6 and keep an extra effect die.

Spirits of Winter (Mob)

They're coming.

MOB TRAIT: **Hungry Ghosts** 8 8 8

Life-Stealing Chill 6

Invisible Until They Strike 6

Overwhelming Tenacity: When you roll to inflict **Drained**, spend a PP to affect multiple targets. For each additional target, add 6 and keep an extra effect die.

Corrupt Federal Agent (Boss)

They love other people's secrets.

BOSS TRAIT: **Nosy Investigator** 6 6 6 6

Persistence 6

Knows Everyone 8

Forged Warrants 10

This Just Got Real: When you roll to inflict **Demoralised**, spend a PP to affect multiple targets. For each additional target, add 6 and keep an extra effect die.

Off-the-Grid Vampire (STC)

Bloodsucking nocturnal marauder.

Shadow Roles: **Speaker** ◆8, **Soldier** 10

Illusion 10

Underground Lair 6

Unquestioning Blood Cultists ◆8

Overgrown Claws and Fangs ◆8

Centuries-old Undead ◆8

Claws & Fangs: Reveal your natural weapons to add 6 to your pool and step up any stress inflicted.

Eternal Hunger (Limit): Each day at sunset, step down all stress except **Drained**, then take **Drained** 6 unless you've slumbered since the last sunset.

Relentless Thirst: Each time you inflict **Drained** stress on a living human or Night Folk, apply the same effect die as recovery to your own **Drained** stress. When you increase a creature's **Drained** to 12 or larger, it takes **Damaged** 12 as well.

Undead Might: Take **Drained** 6 to step down your **Damaged**, to gain a PP, or to step up **Soldier** until the scene ends. You can never recover **Drained** stress except via SFX.

Vampiric Weaknesses (Limit): Step down your roles whenever the sun is up. When you take **Drained** stress from sunlight, stakes, fire, or faith, step up that stress, gain a PP, and shut down ***Undead Fortitude*** until you sleep continuously for at least eight hours.

Appendix A: Distinction Builder

For help in building distinctions, this appendix presents five tables and the guidelines for using them. The tables are the Descriptor Table, the Noun Table, the Catchphrase Table, the Tradition Table, and the Convention Table. Use the tables however you want, whether as lists to pick from or as random tables you pull from by rolling dice. You can choose or roll a descriptor from the Descriptor Table, and then add it to a noun. You can also choose or roll a noun from the Noun Table, and then add a descriptor to it. Or if you really need inspiration you can do both (this is especially useful for your background distinction).

To use abt table, choose any entry on the table, or you can roll randomly. If you are rolling for descriptor or noun, first roll a d12 and find the row for the resulting number. Then roll a d4, and find the column for that result. Your random descriptor or noun is where the row meets the column. If you are rolling for a catchphrase roll a d8 for the row and a d4, for the result column. For a random Tradition roll a d10, and a d6 for a Technocratic Convention.

Descriptor Table

Descriptor	1	2	3	4
1	Affable	Arrogant	Blunt	Bookish
2	Brooding	Charming	Conflicted	Creative
3	Dashing	Defiant	Dutiful	Earnest
4	Eccentric	Faithful	Fearless	Genius
5	Gentle	Grim	Icy	Insecure
6	Logical	Lonely	Loyal	Maverick
7	Misfit	Naïve	Nurturing	Optimist
8	Pacifist	Passionate	Pessimist	Quiet
9	Quirky	Reckless	Rude	Ruthless
10	Sarcastic	Shady	Stubborn	Tenacious
11	Thoughtful	Timid	Vengeful	Veteran
12	Weird	Wise	Young	Zealous

Noun Table

Noun	1	2	3	4
1	Artist	Assassin	Athlete	Believer
2	Bodyguard	Comrade	Crafter	Criminal
3	Deceiver	Detective	Diplomat	Expatriate
4	Expert	Extrovert	Freak	Fugitive
5	Gambler	Guard	Heir	Historian
6	Hunter	Imposter	Introvert	Inventor
7	Kid	Leader	Loner	Mediator
8	Mercenary	Nurse	Occultist	Outsider
9	Parent	Performer	Physician	Rebel
10	Refugee	Romantic	Smuggler	Spy
11	Student	Teacher	Thief	Traveller
12	Vagabond	Vigilante	Visionary	Warrior

Catchphrase Table

Catchphrase	1	2	3	4
1	Act first, ask questions later.	Actually, that's a funny story...	Come at me!	Couldn't stop now if I tried.
2	I have a cunning plan.	I play to win.	I saw this coming.	I'm the best there ever was.
3	It's almost too easy...	I've seen this before.	Lead from the front.	Never give up.
4	Never tell me the odds.	No one's getting paid enough for this	Nobody asked for that.	Sacrifices must be made.
5	Someone had to do it.	Something doesn't feel right	Stop, or be stopped.	Perhaps there's a simpler way...
6	There's always a way.	Things can always get worse.	This is our destiny.	Time to rage!
7	Victory comes at price.	We didn't get dressed up for nothing.	We don't have time for this.	We have unfinished business.
8	Well, isn't this ironic?	We're better than this.	We've got this.	You haven't thought this through.

Tradition Table

Tradition	Name
1	Akashayana/Akashic Brotherhood
2	Celestial Chorus
3	Cult of Ecstasy/Sahajiya
4	Dreamspeakers/Kha'vadi
5	Euthanatoi/Chakravanti
6	Order of Hermes
7	Society of Ether/Sons of Ether
8	Verbena
9	Virtual Adepts
10	Reroll

Convention Table

Convention	Name
1	Iteration X
2	New World Order
3	Progenitors
4	Syndicate
5	Void Engineers
6	Reroll

Appendix B: SFX & Limits

Provided below are lists of SFX and Limits your character may gain at character creation or during play.

SFX List

A Thousand Faces (Gear): Double **Scoundrel** or **Speaker** on a roll to create a disguise asset for yourself. Also, you can spend a PP to step up a disguise asset you already created.

Abjure the Unholy: When you roll to avoid complications or stress inflicted by demons, devils, or undead, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Acolyte Militant: When you succeed on a roll to inflict stress on fiends, undead, or enemies of your faith, spend a PP to step up that stress.

Acrobat: When you climb, flip, or jump for tactical advantage as part of your action, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Aggressive Sorcery: Take **Drained** 6 to step up when rolling to control elemental forces or to inflict complications with magic. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Alchemist's Lore: Take **Drained** 6 to step up when rolling to magically alter the form or physical properties of creatures of objects. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

All-Out Attack: Spend a PP to target multiple opponents when you roll to inflict **Damaged**. For each additional target, add a 6 and keep an extra effect die.

Anointed Weapon: Take **Drained** 6 to infuse holy energy into a weapon you hold, creating a 8 asset.

Arcane Cunning: When you roll to avoid a magical complication, spend a PP to step up **Scholar** or **Scoundrel** and step up your effect die.

Armour Expert (Gear): When your roll to avoid fails, if that roll included an armour asset, step down the stress you take, then step down the asset until it is repaired.

Aura of Faith: When an ally within your reach takes **Demoralised** from fear or doubt, either of you can spend a PP to step down the stress the ally takes. If this steps it down below 6, they take no stress at all.

Auxiliary Operational Mode (Gear): Step down the highest die in your pool to step up an effect die when someone is attempting to unweave or counterspell the magick enacted using your gadgets and devices.

Away From It All: When you first enter a wild space, spend a PP to step down your **Demoralised**, or **Enraged**.

Balm: When you recover non-**Damaged** stress, spend a PP to apply the recovery to more than one character. For each additional target, add 6 and keep an extra effect die.

Barroom Brawler (Gear): When your roll to inflict includes an improvised weapon asset you created during the current scene, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Beastform: Take on an animal form by creating an appropriate asset (**Eagle Form**, **Shape of a Bear**, etc.) and stay in that form as long as the asset lasts. When you create the asset, step down one of your roles and step up another. Recover your roles' normal ratings by eliminating the asset.

Better Under Pressure: Spend a PP to add your **Demoralised** or **Enraged** to your roll to create an asset. If the action succeeds, step down the stress you used.

Blessed Orator: When you roll to preach to a crowd, spend a PP to add a 6 to your pool for every audience member beyond the first. Assign an effect die to each listener as an asset for them or as **Demoralised**.

Bottle Up Your Feelings: Take a **Emotionless** 6 complication to create a **Bottled Emotions** 8 asset: a magical bottle holding your emotions. While you have it, take **Emotionless** 6 at the start of each scene, but whenever you would take **Demoralised** or **Enraged**, step up **Emotionless** instead. You can end the asset voluntarily by drinking the bottle, otherwise when the asset ends, the bottle explodes. If **Emotionless** would step up past 12, end the asset instead. When the bottle asset ends, any **Emotionless** complication you have turns into **Demoralised**.

Brace and Aim (Gear): If you haven't moved yet during your turn, spend a PP to give yourself a 8 asset related to aiming with a ranged weapon. Remove this asset if you move more than two paces during a single beat.

Building Momentum: When you succeed on a roll to inflict stress or complication, spend a PP to gain or step up the asset **Momentum** 6. If you fail any roll or make a recovery roll, eliminate the asset.

Burglar: If you are about to be discovered somewhere you're not supposed to be, you may spend a PP to gain a 8 asset to conceal you.

Burnt Offerings: Step down an offering asset to earn a PP or step down your **Drained**. It's up to ST to decide if an asset is a worthy offering.

Burst of Strength: Spend a PP or take **Enraged** 6 to step up or on a roll related to feats of physical strength, raw muscle, or sheer physical might.

Catch 'Em Flat-Footed: When you roll to inflict stress on a target who hasn't yet taken a turn this scene, add 8 and step up your effect die.

Cerebral: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up on a roll related to intellect, reasoning, memory, or aptitude for learning.

Chalice Lighter: When you light a flame to meditate on a named conflict, spend a PP to gain a 8 asset related to understanding the questions you believe are central to that conflict.

Charismatic: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Speaker** on a roll related to presence, social graces, leadership, or personal magnetism.

Chimerical Image: Spend a PP to double on a roll to create a magical illusion.

Claws & Fangs: When using your natural weapons created by magick step up any stress your successful roll inflicts.

Cleanse: When you roll to recover another character's complication (including stress), take **Drained** 6 to step up your effect die. You may do this more than once on a single roll.

Close the Distance (Gear): When you switch from ranged combat to close combat or back, step down the largest die in your pool for that roll to earn a PP.

Combat Veteran: When your roll to inflict **Damaged** or **Demoralised** during a battle includes **Soldier**, step down the largest die in your pool to add 8. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Con Artist: When you roll to deceive someone or maintain an existing deception, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Conjured Elemental: Spend a PP to create a ◆8 asset, representing an elemental creature summoned to aid you until the end of the scene or you banish it.

Connections in Low Places: Spend a PP to reveal a personal connection — shared childhood, marriage relation, worked the same crew, or the like — to a person of little social standing, gaining a ◆8 asset related to that person.

Creature Lore: When your roll related to discerning information about or detecting non-humanoid creatures includes **Scout**, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Deadeye (Gear): When you roll to inflict **Damaged** with a ranged weapon, if your roll includes an asset you created relating to aiming, step up your effect die.

Detect Weakness: When you succeed on a roll to inflict **Damaged**, spend a PP to step up your effect die.

Dextrous Agility: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Scout**, **Scoundrel**, or **Soldier** on a roll related to swiftness, deftness, balance, or hand-eye coordination.

Dimensional Magic: Take **Drained** 6 to step up **Spirit** or **Correspondence** when rolling to summon and control something from elsewhere, or to use teleportation or portals. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Dimensional Vagabond: When stepping sideways spend a PP to double **Spirit** in your pool.

Dirty Fighter: Immediately before or after rolling against a foe, spend a PP to stoop to dishonourable tactics and inflict a 6 complication like **Sand in Eyes** or **Sucker Punch** on that opponent.

Distracting Presence: When you roll to inflict **Enthralled** by distracting someone, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Divine Providence: When the ST rolls an opportunity, take **Enthralled** 6 to earn a PP. You can immediately spend it to activate that opportunity.

Dual Wield (Gear): When you wield a weapon in each hand on a roll to inflict stress, step down the pool's largest die to keep an extra effect die.

Eldritch Obfuscation: Take **Drained** 6 to step **Mind** up when rolling to manipulate others' senses with a supernatural effect. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Elusive Dodge: Step up **Scoundrel** or **Scout** on your roll to avoid a complication or stress that affects an entire area.

Embolden the Spirits: When using magick step up a die in your pool but 1s and 2s count as hitches as inhabitants of the other side get rowdy and unrestrained from your magick.

Empathic Practice: Step up **Speaker** on a roll to create an asset related to trust, reading people, or reassurance.

Envenomed Weapon (Gear): When you succeed on a roll to inflict **Damaged** with a weapon while you have a poison-related asset, if your total is an even number, keep an additional effect die as a complication against the same foe.

Erudite Researcher (Gear): When you spend an hour or more with good sources (a library, a meticulous ledger, accurate maps, informed and cooperative experts, etc.) add 6 and step up your effect die on rolls to create research-based assets.

Evading: When you roll to create an asset or recover stress, spend a PP to keep and step up a second effect die as an asset for yourself related to avoiding physical harm. This asset immediately ends if you roll to inflict stress or complications, but while you have it, if an SFX would allow someone to inflict stress on you by spending a PP, you ignore that stress.

Every Move You Make: While you are observing a person or situation without haste or interruption, spend a PP to double your **Scout** for one roll.

Expend Willpower: When exert extraordinary effort to succeed, take **Demoralised** 6 to gain a PP or add a third die to your total on a roll.

Expert Healer: When you roll to help an ally recover **Damaged** or **Demoralised**, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Exploit Weakness: Spend a PP to double your target's stress die in your roll to inflict stress on them.

Familiar Bond: When you suffer Backlash you can step down your familiar asset to ignore it. If the Backlash effect die is larger than the asset shut it down instead. Recover the asset the same way as **Drained** stress.

Fence: When you reveal that you've found a buyer for stolen goods or a seller of necessary (but probably stolen) goods, gain them as a ◆ asset as well as the complication **Disreputable** 6.

First Strike: When you roll to inflict stress on a foe, if it's the first time you've rolled to inflict stress on that foe this scene, step up your effect die.

Flanking: While you and an ally are both within reach of the same foe, but not within each other's reach, you both add 6 to your rolls to attack that foe.

Flash of Insight: When you fail a test to obtain information, you may spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to obtain that information by other means.

Focused Stillness (Gear): If you haven't moved yet during your turn when you roll to use a ranged weapon that you're wielding with two hands, you can step up one asset in your pool and step up any stress you inflict.

Glade Keeper: When you take a complication while defending a wild or sacred place from encroachment or corruption, you can either step up that complication to earn a PP or spend a PP to immediately step it down.

Greater Divination: Take **Drained** 6 to step up a Sphere when rolling to gain information or reveal knowledge with magic. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Guards & Wards: Take **Drained** 6 to step up when rolling to cast protective magic or to dispel or exorcize supernatural influences. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Have a Little Faith: When you would take **Demoralised** stress, spend a PP to step down the stress you take. If this steps the stress down below 6, you take no stress at all.

Healing Touch: Roll to create an asset related to healing magic, which lasts until the session ends or until it steps down below 6. Step down the asset to step down the or of one creature you touch.

Heart's Blood: Take Damaged d6 to earn a PP or step down your **Drained**.

Heist Planner: Immediately after you create an asset, spend a PP to step up that asset by narrating a flashback to when and how you prepared for this contingency.

Hell on Wheels: Double or on a roll to manoeuvre a vehicle or mount, or to outrun someone or avoid falling. If the roll succeeds, step up your effect die. Also, while you are mounted or in a vehicle, if an SFX would allow someone to inflict stress on you by spending a PP, you ignore that stress.

Heroic Agility: When you roll to avoid stress and fail, if the opposition's total didn't beat yours by five or more, spend a PP to step down the opposition's effect die.

High Stamina: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Scout** or **Soldier** on a roll related to constitution, toughness, endurance, or general health.

Hinder: Roll ▼ instead of ◆ for a distinction to earn a PP.

How It's Made: Spend a PP either when modifying an existing tool or jury-rigging a new one for an effect not normally possible using it to gain a ◆ asset related to the effect.

Hunting the Dark: When you roll to inflict a complication or stress on the undead or a creature of shadow, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Impossible to Ignore: Spend a PP to target multiple opponents when you roll to inflict **Enthralled**. For each additional target, add 6 and keep an extra effect die.

In Harm's Way: When another character near you takes stress, you can step down the stress they would take, then take 6 stress of the same type yourself.

Inquisitive: When you fail a roll to obtain information, spend a PP to reroll all your dice.

Inspiring Leadership: Add a 6 and step up your effect die when you roll **Speaker** to create assets for allies.

It's Gonna Blow: Double your Sphere when overloading, boosting or otherwise pushing the limits of one of the gadgets and tools that you use. Grow Paradox once immediately.

Juke: When you fail a roll to evade harm, spend a PP to reroll all your dice.

Keen Intellect: Add a 6 and step up your effect die when you roll **Scholar** to create an asset related to recalling or researching information.

Lifesaving Asset: While you have a magical asset that is a physical object, when you would take **Damaged**, you can sacrifice the asset instead of taking the stress.

Maintaining Composure: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Speaker** or **Soldier** on a roll related to tenacity, resolve, staying calm, reassuring someone, or keeping emotions in check.

Manipulative Instincts: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Speaker** or **Scoundrel** on a roll related to reading people, manipulating emotions, or influencing someone's actions.

Master Plan: Spend a PP to add a die to your pool equal to the largest complication anyone has in the scene. After the roll fails or succeeds, step down that complication.

Misdirection: When you use **Scoundrel** on a roll related to escape, deception, or stealth, step down the largest die in your pool to add ◆8. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Natural Leader: When someone besides you rolls an asset you created in their pool, spend a PP to double that asset. If that roll succeeds, and step up its effect die.

Nature Provides (Gear): When you roll to create an asset for someone else using natural materials, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Network: While in a populated settlement, spend a PP to create ◆8 asset in the form of a STC who provides free room and board for you and your allies. As long as you don't overstay your welcome or cause trouble, the STC will even help hide your presence.

Oak & Mistletoe (Gear): When your roll using magic to create assets or recover stress uses an implement made of wood or other plant matter that you crafted yourself, add 6 and step up your effect die.

One of Their Own: Spend a PP to create a ◆8 asset representing a friendly local spirit willing to aid you for a time.

Opportune Attack (Gear): When a foe willingly moves out of your reach without teleporting, spend a PP to inflict **Damaged** 6 on that creature if you have a melee weapon in hand.

Outmanoeuvre: When your roll to inflict **Damaged** or **Drained** while outdoors includes **Scout**, step down the largest die in your pool to add ◆8. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Palm It (Gear): When you roll to hide a one-handed weapon or make a sneak attack with it, step up and double the smallest die in your pool if you aren't wearing armour or using a shield.

Paramedic Training: Step up or double **Scholar** in your dice pool when helping others recover **Damaged**. You can also spend a PP to step down your own or a nearby character's **Damaged**.

Patient Healer: When you take your time to help someone, you may reroll one die that rolls a hitch on your rolls to recover their stress.

Peacemaker: If you have **Damaged** inflicted by another character in the scene when you roll to de-escalate a conflict, double **Speaker** in your dice pool. If the roll still fails, take **Demoralised** 6.

Perceptive: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to double your role on a roll related to alertness, intuition, sensory acuity, or overall awareness of your environment.

Poison Expert (Gear): Spend a PP to coat an appropriate weapon in poison, creating a ◆8 asset, or to double your largest die on a roll to detect, identify, treat, or brew poison.

Position of Privilege: While in a populated settlement, spend a PP to create a ◆8 asset who is an attendant or guide, seeing to basic needs and logistics while you're in the area.

Prayer of Knowledge: Spend a PP to gain a ◆8 specialty you don't already possess until the end of the scene.

Prepared Caster: Double a Sphere on a roll that includes a magickal asset you rolled to create in a previous scene. After the roll is resolved, either spend a PP or step down the asset.

Pretty Good With a Staff (Gear): When you attack with a hafted weapon, step up the smallest die in your pool. On a success, keep an extra effect die as a complication on the target related to battlefield positioning.

Primeval Sense: Spend a PP to create a 8 asset related to wilderness awareness. While you have this asset, you know if there are any unnatural or otherworldly creatures within a mile of you, and can sense their general direction. If you're within a mile of a settlement, all you can sense is the settlement, and your asset is shut down.

Quell The Spirits: When dealing and negotiating with spirits take **Enthralled** 6 to reroll a die in your roll.

Quick Wits: Spend a PP or take **Enthralled** 6 to step up **Scholar**, **Scoundrel**, or **Scout** on a roll related to reflexes, reaction time, thinking fast, or puzzling out enigmas.

Reassuring Comrade: Step up or double **Speaker** in your dice pool when helping others recover **Demoralised**. You can also spend a PP to step down your own or a nearby character's **Demoralised**.

Reckless Gambit: When you roll dice, add a die to your pool equal to the largest stress or complication anyone has in the scene. Take a complication at 6 if the roll succeeds, or 8 if it fails.

Reliable Memory: Spend a PP to reroll a dice pool focused on memory or recall that included **Scholar**.

Reliable Specialty: When you fail a roll that included a specialty of 8 or larger, spend a PP to reroll all your dice. Afterwards, shut down this SFX until the end of the scene.

Requisitions: Take a **Indebted** 8 complication to create a 8 Wonder asset you temporarily possess and shut down the SFX. Recover by recovering the complication.

Note to STs, the complication shouldn't be too simple to recover.

Righteous Condemnation: When you criticize someone for improper, cruel, or unfaithful actions, you may spend a PP to step down your **Demoralised**.

Rods, Staves, & Wands (Gear): When your roll using magic to inflict stress or a complication includes an asset that is a rod, staff, or wand, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Rote Memorization: When your roll includes an asset representing a rote, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Seasoned Sailor: When you roll to swim, to create an asset related to your career at sea, or to inflict a complication or stress on a sea creature, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Sharpened Senses: When you take a complication related to stealth, deception, or illusion, you can immediately spend a PP to step down that complication.

Skill Focus: When your pool includes a specialty, you can replace two dice of equal size with one die one step larger.

Storied History: When interacting with spirits spend a PP to introduce a details about the entity you're interacting with, whether it be past dealings, past connections, forgotten oath, etc represented by a 8 asset.

Stormshroud: When using weather (natural or summoned) to hide your presence or that of your allies, step up your effect die.

Striking Appearance: Spend a PP or take **Demoralised** 6 to step up **Speaker** on a roll leveraging either your physical beauty or distinctive unattractiveness.

Student of Necromancy: Take **Drained** 6 to step up **Death** when rolling to create or affect undead. If your roll succeeds, step up your effect die.

Sudden Yet Inevitable: When someone betrays you or deceives you, or you betray or deceive someone, spend a PP to create a ◆ asset related to having planned for it.

Take the Heat: When an ally fails a roll to avoid **Demoralised**, or a complication, spend a PP to let them reroll all their dice. If the roll still fails, take an [Exposed 6] complication to step down the stress or complication the ally takes.

Touché: When you acknowledge an opponent's success against you, step down the complication their roll inflicts and take **Demoralised** 6.

Tough: When you would take **Damaged**, spend a PP to step down the stress you take. If this steps the stress down below 6, you take no stress at all.

Trust Me, I'm an Engineer: When using magick spend a PP to turn a vulgar effect into a coincidental one if you are being observed by uneducated Sleepers, then shut down this SFX. Activate an opportunity to recover.

Two-Weapon Defence (Gear): When a foe within reach rolls to inflict stress on you while you are wielding a melee weapon in each hand, spend a PP to create a ◆ asset related to your defence.

Undaunted Determination: Step up or double **Scout** for one roll. If the roll fails, take **Drained** stress equal to the largest die in your pool.

Unobtrusive: Spend a PP to double your distinction on a roll while you are pretending to be a mundane animal.

Versatile Grip (Gear): When you roll to use a weapon that can be wielded one-handed or two-handed, if you wield it with two hands, you can double your attribute. If you fail, step up the stress you take from failing.

Vicious Contempt: When you roll to inflict **Demoralised** with mockery or contempt, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Vigilant Eye: Spend a PP to double **Scout** in a pool related to following a trail, aiming at a distant target, or spotting something far off.

Vigilantism: When you roll to inflict a complication or stress on someone you caught committing a serious crime, or whom you know to be part of criminal organization or unlawful conspiracy, add 6 and step up your effect die.

Vulgar Display of Power: When you roll to use in a particularly flashy or impossible way, grow Paradox to double and step up your effect die.

War Magic: When you succeed on a roll to inflict **Damaged** using a magical asset, keep a second effect die as a complication or another form of stress against the same foe.

Watch the World Burn: Step up the largest doom die, then add a die of equal size to your pool and step up your effect die. Succeed or fail, you take **Enthralled** 6.

We Need More Funding: Consume an asset representing wealth improving the material conditions of your experiments or making relevant persons more pliable to double a die when performing a ritual.

What's the Worst That Can Happen: When you roll to create an asset for a desperate or dubious plan of action, explain to another character what the worst-case failure scenario looks like to step up your largest die and step up your effect die. Add a die to the peril pool equal to your effect die.

Wicked Feint: When you succeed on a roll to inflict **Enthralled**, keep a second effect die as **Damaged** against the same foe.

Wild Wisdom: Spend a PP to reveal information about a wild landscape or creature and create a related a ◆ asset.

Limit List

All the Hard Work (Limit): When you expend exhausting effort to solve someone else's problem, take **Drained** 6 to earn a PP. If you actually receive fair compensation for it, gain another PP.

Ammunition (Limit): Earn a PP and step down an asset for a ranged weapon, representing a need to conserve ammunition. Whenever the ST activates a hitch on a roll you make with the stepped down asset, they can choose to shut down the asset instead of giving you a complication. Whether the asset is stepped down or shut down, recover it when you refresh your ammo supply.

Bleeding Heart (Limit): When you expose yourself to danger by showing compassion, earn a PP and take a **Mistrusted** 6 complication.

Bound by Tradition (Limit): When you pay deference to an ancient, exalted, or royal being, or when you detract from your larger goals by adhering to tradition, take **Enthralled** 6 to earn a PP.

Code of Conduct (Limit): When you take an action that violates the honourable code of behaviour you have pledged to live by, earn a PP and take **Demoralised** 6.

Compulsive Secrecy (Limit): When you keep a secret even though doing so is detrimental to your larger goals, take a related 6 complication to earn a PP.

Conspicuous (Limit): When your actions or your flamboyant use of supernatural powers attract unwanted attention, take **Exposed** 6 complication to earn a PP.

Country Mouse (Limit): When in an urban area, take a related 6 complication or **Demoralised** 6 to earn a PP.

Curiosity (Limit): Take a 6 complication related to indulging your curiosity in a dangerous situation to earn a PP.

Dark Omens (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing how the current situation is more dangerous than it seems and/or how a past tragedy is on the verge of repeating itself. You then take **Demoralised** 6 or **Enthralled** 6.

Deeply Flawed (Limit): When you use *Hinder* on a roll, after the roll is resolved, you can step up one existing stress you have to earn a PP.

Dig Too Deep (Limit): When you've started something and it's probably a bad idea to keep working at it, but you stick with it anyway, take a **Stubborn** 6 complication to earn a PP.

Distressingly Familiar (Limit): Reveal a detrimental detail about a situation, location, creature, or faction that you've encountered before to earn a PP, then take a related 6 complication.

Eager for Attention (Limit): When you perform for an audience or show off in front of strangers, take ENTHRALLED 6 to earn a PP.

Easy Way Out (Limit): When you are tempted to give into fear, desire, social pressure, or the instinct to acquire more power, take DEMORALISED 6 or ENTHRALLED 6 to earn a PP.

Encumbered (Limit): When your body armour or other heavy gear interferes with your movement, gain a related complication at 6 to earn a PP.

Guilty Conscience (Limit): When you act against your own sense of morality, take DEMORALISED 6 (if you feel bad about it) or add 6 to the peril pool (if you don't), then earn a PP.

Hair-Trigger Temper (Limit): When you perceive someone as having deceived, insulted, or goaded you, take ENTHRALLED 6 or an ENRAGED 6 complication to earn a PP.

Hard on My Gear (Limit): Shut down a signature asset to earn a PP. To restore it, succeed on a special test against the ST.

Head in the Clouds (Limit): When you are distracted by a torrent of information provided by your magic, research, or supernatural insights, take ENTHRALLED 6 to earn a PP.

Hoarder (Limit): When you could trade or spend money to make things easier, but you refuse, take a POSSESSIVE 6 complication to earn a PP.

I'll Guard the Henhouse (Limit): When you play up the air of danger that surrounds you, take a MISTRUSTED 6 complication to earn a PP.

It Can't Be This Easy (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing why an opponent must have already anticipated your current course of action and/or why your seeming moment of victory is only temporary. You then take DEMORALISED 6 or ENTHRALLED 6.

Misunderstood (Limit): When you feel the burden of others' assumptions about you, take DEMORALISED 6 or a MISTRUSTED 6 complication to earn a PP.

Need for Control (Limit): When someone you expected to comply disobeys your direct order, take DEMORALISED 6 or ENRAGED 6 stress to earn a PP.

No Angel (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing how a past misdeed has come back to haunt you in the current scene, or that you must now separate from the group to deal with the fallout from a bad choice you made. You then take DEMORALISED 6 or ENTHRALLED 6 stress.

Not Safe Yet (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing why you and your allies cannot yet escape or stop and rest, and/or that you've become aware of someone following or watching you. You then take DEMORALISED 6 or ENTHRALLED 6 stress.

Outrage (Limit): When you loudly condemn someone who has broken your culture's traditions or disrespected you, earn a PP and take a ENRAGED 6.

Perfectionist (Limit): When you fail at something, take DEMORALISED 6 or ENTHRALLED 6 stress to earn a PP. (This is in addition to any stress you take from a failed dice roll.)

Rebellious Instincts (Limit): When you indulge in an act of rebellion detrimental to your larger goals, take a related 6 complication or **Enraged** 6 to earn a PP.

Righteous Urgency (Limit): Earn a PP when you reveal how a situation is likely to harm vulnerable people, how you must address an affront to your beliefs, or why you feel compelled to help someone who deserves punishment. You then take your choice of **Demoralised** 6, **Enthralled** 6, or **Enraged** 6.

Sacred Ground (Limit): Whenever you enter a space sacred to your culture or belief system, take **Enthralled** 6 to earn a PP.

Seeing Beyond Mundane Reality (Limit): When you attempt to focus all your attention on something, take **Enthralled** 6 representing distracting visions or skewed perceptions to earn a PP.

Seeing Red (Limit): When anger prompts you to focus all your attention on a single object or person, take **Enthralled** 6 to step down all your other complications and stresses.

Shady Backstory (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing that a STC or group knows a dangerous secret, or that they are after you for a past crime or perceived betrayal. You then take **Demoralised** 6 or **Enthralled** 6.

Split Allegiances (Limit): Choose a second faction in addition to your existing one. You don't gain the faction's bonus signature asset or specialities, but you can choose from its faction SFX when gaining new SFX. When you are torn between your two allegiances, take a related 6 complication to earn a PP.

Sworn Enemy (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing that a misdeed committed by a STC or faction now urgently requires you to bring them to justice, take vengeance on them, or save someone they endangered. You then take **Enthralled** 6 or an **Enraged** 6.

The Road Goes Ever On (Limit): When your homesickness threatens to overwhelm you, or you complain about your lack of creature comforts, take **Demoralised** 6 to earn a PP.

Underdeveloped Powers (Limit): When your dice pool includes a Sphere, remove the largest die from your pool to earn a PP.

Unwanted Attention (Limit): When you arrive somewhere new, earn a PP and gain a 6 complication related to someone you hadn't met before already deciding they hate you, they want to use you, or they have unreciprocated affection towards you. Instead of just going away at the end of the scene, the complication automatically goes away at the end of the session.

Wanderlust (Limit): When your urge to go experience new places threatens to overwhelm you, take **Enthralled** 6 to earn a PP.

We've Got History (Limit): After a new STC is introduced, you can earn a PP by revealing that the STC was once your friend, ally, or lover, until you parted on very bad terms. You then take **Demoralised** 6 or **Enthralled** 6.

Weapon Focus (Limit): Whenever you are unarmed or have a complication that impairs your use of a weapon, shut down a related (Gear) SFX to earn a PP. Recover at the start of the next scene.

Working On It (Limit): Earn a PP by revealing that you can't complete an urgent task because you are missing something crucial that's difficult to obtain or because you need much more time than is currently feasible. Then take **Demoralised** 6 or **Enthralled** 6.

Appendix C: Example Milestones

These are milestones you can use for characters during play, or as examples to help you create your own.

Aggressive

- *1 XP* when you are the one who starts a conflict or you take charge in the midst of one.
- *3 XP* when you teach an ally to make them more formidable in the kinds of conflicts you consider your expertise.
- *10 XP* when you take over leadership of your group in a time of danger or leave your current group to join a more aggressive one.

Bad Influence

- *1 XP* when you try to convince an ally to commit or cover up an unlawful or antisocial act.
- *3 XP* when you try to convince someone to accept their own past misdeeds, true nature, or current infamy.
- *10 XP* when you decide to change your ways for good, or when you commit a transgression too egregious for your allies to forgive.

Cipher

- *1 XP* when you decline to reveal information about yourself but still betray stray details or clues.
- *3 XP* when you explain your motivation for an unexpected choice or action.
- *10 XP* when you finally reveal major details about your identity, background, or motivations in the face of a challenge with at least one 12 trait, hoping the revealed knowledge will help overcome it.

Comrade

- *1 XP* when you create an asset for a friend or ally who doesn't already have an asset from you.
- *3 XP* when you expose yourself to danger as part of a roll to create an asset to help someone or a roll to recover a stress or complication for an ally or STC.
- *10 XP* when an asset you earned XP for helps defeat a challenge with at least one 12 trait, or when you abandon comrades in a moment of need to pursue your own agenda.

Disruptor

- *1 XP* when you publicly disrespect an authority figure.
- *3 XP* when you undermine or outright attack an authority figure or one of their representatives.
- *10 XP* when you destroy the credibility or power of an authority figure who has at least one 12 trait or when you accept their authority.

Empathetic

- *1 XP* when you create an asset for an ally without them having to ask.
- *3 XP* when you succeed on a roll to create an asset for an ally in a situation where it is dangerous to do so.

- *10 XP* when an asset you earned XP for helps defeat a challenge that had at least one 12 trait, or when failing against such a challenge prompts you to leave the group and learn how to be practical or self-reliant.

Goal-Driven

- *1 XP* when you act to either affirm or conceal your commitment to a goal.
- *3 XP* when you recruit a new ally in pursuit of a goal or you betray or abandon allies to attain that goal.
- *10 XP* when defeating a challenge with at least one trait at 12 moves you closer to fulfilling a drive-related goal, or when you finally abandon a goal you've sacrificed to pursue.

Glory Hound

- *1 XP* when you take out an opponent after you dramatically declared them your target.
- *3 XP* when you attempt a reckless but glorious deed, or when you abstain from such a deed out of caution.
- *10 XP* when you assume leadership responsibilities due to your impressive deeds, or stand alone against a foe with at least one 12 trait.

Hiding In The Shadows

- *1 XP* when you take action to stay out of the spotlight.
- *3 XP* when you leave the shadows to accomplish something important.
- *10 XP* when you step into the spotlight in front of a large group in order to accomplish something important, or when you try to leave your group to survive alone.

Intuitive

- *1 XP* when you share insights based on looking at the big picture or create an asset based on perceiving deeper connections.
- *3 XP* when you succeed on a roll to create an asset based on spontaneously changing plans in the moment or doing something surprising.
- *10 XP* when an asset you earned XP for helps defeat a challenge with at least one 12 trait, or when failing against such a challenge prompts you to ask for guidance on how to be more logical or methodical.

Levelling Up

- *1 XP* when you earn a PP from an SFX or Limit (such as Hinder).
- *3 XP* when you help someone else recover from stress or you succeed on a roll to create an asset for an ally.
- *10 XP* when you recover from stress of 12 or larger, or when an asset you created for someone else helps defeat a challenge that has at least one trait at 12.

Lone Wolf

- *1 XP* when you leave your allies to face a dangerous or hated enemy, or when you create an asset that requires taking time alone.

- *3 XP* when your actions prompt criticism or dismay in your allies, or when you issue a threat that risks alienating an ally.
- *10 XP* when you finally take out someone you've been hunting on your own that has at least one ⓬ trait, or when you give up your chance at doing so to achieve something greater.

Looking For Redemption

- *1 XP* when you point out someone else's wrongdoing or express regret for your own.
- *3 XP* when you refuse to grant leniency, or when you choose not to punish a wrongdoer.
- *10 XP* when you announce that you feel you have finally paid for your crimes, or when you announce your final acceptance of the fact that you never will.

Loose Cannon

- *1 XP* when you take reckless action without consulting anyone else.
- *3 XP* when you dismiss or diminish the fallout of your own actions.
- *10 XP* when you risk your life without calculation or planning and the risk either succeeds in bettering the lives of many or costs you deeply (or both).

Mending Fences

- *1 XP* when a long-time friend, family member, or loved one rejects you in some way, or when you try to get them to let you back into their life.
- *3 XP* when you try to get closer to someone you care about by taking on a new role or obligation.
- *10 XP* when you are stressed out while trying to protect or be closer to the person you care about, or when you destroy any progress you've made by stressing them out.

Mercenary

- *1 XP* when you seek payment.
- *3 XP* when you act callously to benefit yourself or when you receive payment for services rendered.
- *10 XP* when you betray a friend or ally for a big payout, or when you agree to do so but then refuse at the last moment.

Methodical

- *1 XP* when you create an asset based on planning ahead or attention to detail.
- *3 XP* when you succeed on a roll to create an asset based on noticing a flaw or using deductive reasoning.
- *10 XP* when an asset you earned XP for helps defeat a challenge that had at least one ⓬ trait, or when failing against such a challenge prompts you to follow the example of someone who is more flexible, intuitive, or spontaneous.

Natural Leader

- *1 XP* when you give orders to allies (whether or not they listen).
- *3 XP* when you create an asset based on working together or talking people into things.

- *10 XP* when your group officially recognizes you as their leader, when a rival claims a leadership role you believe should've been yours, or when you announce your realization that you're not the leader your group needs.

Obscure Knowledge

- *1 XP* when you share an insight based on your knowledge of academic subjects or niche trivia.
- *3 XP* when you express an embarrassing amount of excitement over encountering a thing or person you've learned a lot about.
- *10 XP* when your obscure knowledge saves a teammate from disaster, or when you quit the team because your contributions aren't appreciated.

Ongoing Drama

- *1 XP* when you could end a conflict by revealing a secret, but choose not to, or when your deeply held belief causes conflict with another PC.
- *3 XP* when your refusal to act against your belief or reveal a secret causes your group problems or conflict.
- *10 XP* when you reveal one of your secrets publicly, or when your belief or unrevealed secret causes you or another PC to be taken out.

Proving Yourself

- *1 XP* when you talk to a more experienced ally about your insecurities or about the difficult challenges you've already overcome.
- *3 XP* when a more experienced ally grants you an asset, or when you turn down a more experienced ally's offer of help.
- *10 XP* when you take an instrumental role in your group's defeat of a much more powerful enemy, or when you are stressed out while acting recklessly to try to defeat such an enemy.

Religious Believer

- *1 XP* when you take action in concordance with the dictates of your faith.
- *3 XP* when you refuse a temptation to transgress the rules of your faith.
- *10 XP* when the pursuit of your faith prompts you to confront a challenge with at least one ⓬ trait, or you refuse the challenge and abandon such a pursuit.

Schemer

- *1 XP* when you keep or reveal a secret.
- *3 XP* when you first use an asset you created before the current scene.
- *10 XP* when you complete a complicated plan to accomplish a great deed, or abandon the plan in favour of improvisation.

Seeking Justice

- *1 XP* when you declare a crime has been committed or pledge to help someone find justice.
- *3 XP* when you declare you are taking charge of an investigation or successfully track down a wrong- doer.
- *10 XP* when you leave behind a larger duty to focus on your current obligations, or vice-versa.

Unworthy?

- ***1 XP*** when you or an ally vocally question whether you belong in a group.
- ***3 XP*** when you dramatically succeed or fail in a situation where your allies depend on you, or when you inflict a non-injurious complication or stress on an ally who doubts you.
- ***10 XP*** when you are faced with the decision: step up and decide that you are worthy to be a part of the group, or leave the group because you believe you're unworthy.

Valiant

- ***1 XP*** when you declare that your actions forward your cause.
- ***3 XP*** when you create an asset representing dedication to your cause, either for yourself or others.
- ***10 XP*** when you abandon your grand cause to focus on more immediate needs

Wholesome

- ***1 XP*** when you promise to help someone or you unexpectedly aid someone who thought all hope was lost.
- ***3 XP*** when you take ❽ or greater stress trying to fulfil your promise to help someone.
- ***10 XP*** when you confront a challenge with at least one ⓬ trait as part of fulfilling a promise, or when you inform someone that your attempt to help them has proven too difficult for you.

We are mages, people with the power to change the world.

Reality is outs to command and bend.

Not all of us know what to do with our powers.
Even fever can ever realise the extent of our might.

Those that do are Heroes, Gods, Monsters and Tyrants.

In our world blessed few Awaken. Add even fewer do so without consequences and in peace.

And so reality is up for grabs. Where do you stand?

And will you Fall... or Ascend?

PRIMED BY CORTEX

MAGE

THE ASCENSION